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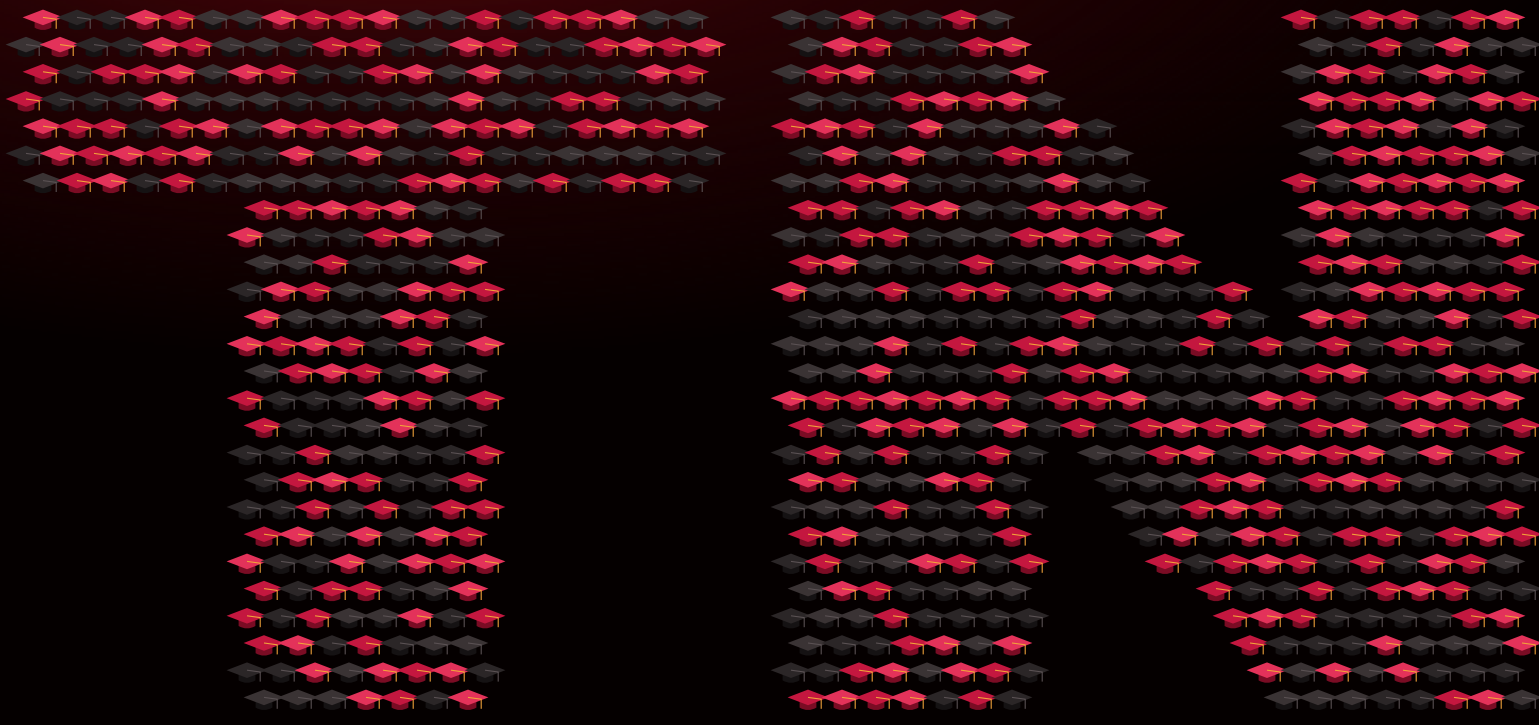
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NOVEMBER 2026

The 2026 Tennessee Talent Profile

Emerson Johnston
Amy Zegart

The bright caps, **50 in every 100**, mark the international share of Tennessee's STEM master's degrees.



The 2026 Tennessee Talent Profile

By Emerson Johnston and Amy Zegart

NOVEMBER 2026

A publication jointly produced by the Hoover Institution and the Institute for Human-Centered Artificial Intelligence at Stanford University.

Table of Contents

OVERVIEW

At a Glance 6

SECTIONS

Section 1 International Dependence 8
Section 2 STEM Degrees 20
Section 3 Where Students Come From 26
Section 4 K-12 Preparation 34
Section 5 Graduate Research 36
Section 6 Do Graduates Stay? 38
Section 7 Research Funding 40
Section 8 H-1B Jobs and Green Cards 42
Section 9 STEM Workforce 46
Section 10 Patents 48
Section 11 Competitors 50
Section 12 Fields of Study 52
Section 13 Students and Money 62
Section 14 Student Outcomes 70
Section 15 Faculty 74
Section 16 Institutions 78

BACK MATTER

About these Data 82
By the Numbers 84
Sources 94

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Data come from the Integrated Postsecondary Education Data System (IPEDS), the Department of Homeland Security's SEVIS by the Numbers, the National Assessment of Educational Progress, NSF's Survey of Graduate Students and Postdoctorates and Survey of Earned Doctorates, the Department of Labor's Office of Foreign Labor Certification, the USCIS H-1B Employer Data Hub, the Census Bureau's American Community Survey and USPTO patent data via PatentsView, processed in Python; every figure and table is generated from those sources, and each one names its source.

About This Profile

This profile is a companion to *The 2026 US Talent Report: Benchmarking America's STEM Pipeline Amid the Great Talent Competition*. It applies the report's measures to Tennessee: the students the state develops at home, those it draws from abroad, and how both compare with the nation and with the states closest to it in size.

Degrees, enrollment, prices, outcomes and faculty come from IPEDS, the federal census of U.S. colleges and universities, harmonized across 1980–2025. Countries of citizenship come from SEVIS by the Numbers, the Department of Homeland Security's monthly count of active F-1 and M-1 students. Each figure names its source. Peer states are the four closest in total fall enrollment.

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Public Data and Tools

The data behind every chart come from federal sources: the Integrated Postsecondary Education Data System (IPEDS), published by the National Center for Education Statistics, as the backbone, together with NAEP, NSF's surveys of graduate students, doctorates and research funding, USAspending.gov, DHS and ICE SEVIS data, the Department of Labor, USCIS, the Census Bureau's American Community Survey and Post-Secondary Employment Outcomes, and USPTO PatentsView. Each figure names its source, and the Sources page lists all of them. An interactive version of this profile accompanies the report.

To share any charts and figures, proper attribution is required. This profile is licensed under Attribution-NoDerivatives 4.0 International (CC BY-ND 4.0). Please cite as: The 2026 Tennessee Talent Profile.

AT A GLANCE

What Tennessee's numbers say

1. **International students earn 50% of Tennessee's STEM master's degrees,** 2.3 points below the U.S. (52%) in 2025, ranking 18th of 51 on dependence. The share is 35% for STEM research doctorates (U.S. 43%) and 3.9% for STEM bachelor's (U.S. 6.6%).
2. **Tennessee awarded 1.14K STEM master's degrees to international students in 2025,** 1.0% of the U.S. total and 23rd of 51 among states. Since 2015 the count changed 4.8×, against 2.2× nationally.
3. **The heaviest dependence is in computer & info sciences,** where international students earned 76% of master's degrees (1.08K degrees; U.S. 65%). 2 STEM fields with at least 50 master's graduates are majority-international.
4. **Among states of similar size,** Tennessee ranks 3rd of 5 on the international share of STEM master's: Tennessee 50%, Wisconsin 55%, Washington 39%, Alabama 43%, Missouri 83%.
5. **76% of Tennessee's first-time students in fall 2024 were state residents** and 1.6% came from abroad. More students arrived from other states (11.7K) than residents left (11.4K), a net gain of 370; the top destination for those leaving was Alabama.

50%

of the STEM master's degrees Tennessee awards go to international students (U.S. 52%).

SCORECARD

Nine numbers against the nation

325K #23
Students enrolled, 2024
U.S. **19.7M** · +0.5% since 2015

1.14K #23
International STEM master's, 2025
U.S. **117K** · 4.83× since 2015

50% #18
International share of STEM master's, 2025
U.S. **52%** · +27.3 pp since 2015

11% #31
International share of grad students, 2024
U.S. **17%** · +2.7 pp since 2015

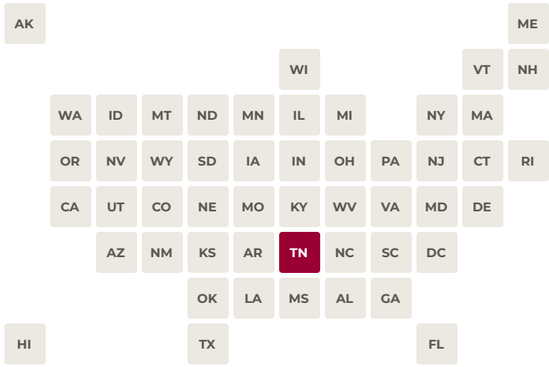
18% #44
STEM share of bachelor's, 2025
U.S. **24%** · +3.4 pp since 2015

58% #36
Six-year graduation rate, 2024
U.S. **65%** · +8.2 pp since 2015

$12.1K #13
Appropriations per student, 2024
U.S. **$11.4K** · +64% since 2015

76% #19
First-time students from in state, 2024
−4.9 pp since 2016

$92.8K #33
Average faculty salary, 2024
U.S. **$106K** · −5.5% since 2016



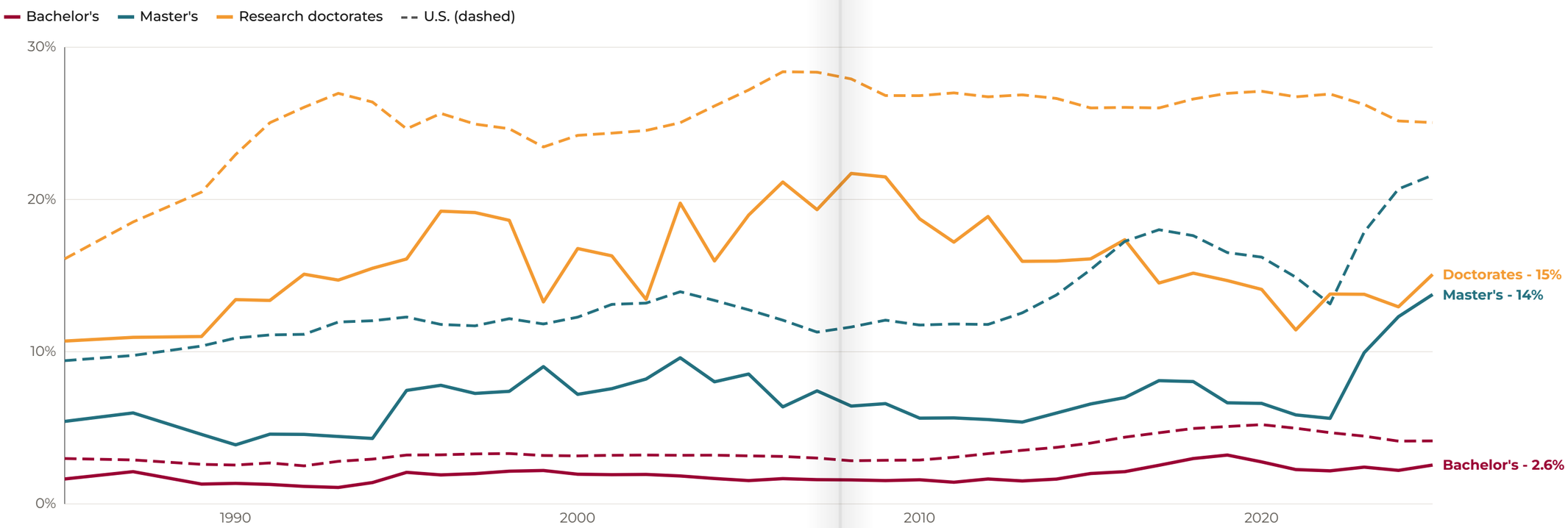
Badges give Tennessee's rank among the 50 states and DC (1 = highest). Changes are since 2015.

SECTION 1

International Dependence

Tennessee ranks 18th of 51 on the international share of STEM master's, at 50% in 2025 against 52% for the U.S.

Figure 1 What Share of Tennessee's Degrees Go to International Students?



International share of degrees awarded, all fields; state solid, U.S. dashed. Data from NCES, IPEDS Completions, 1985–2025.

International students make up 11% of Tennessee's graduate enrollment and 2.0% of its undergraduates. Dependence climbs with each degree: 2.6% of bachelor's, 14% of master's and 15% of research doctorates go to international students.

In STEM the shares are higher still: 3.9% of STEM bachelor's, 50% of STEM master's and 35% of STEM doctorates. The state awards 1.0% of all U.S. international STEM master's, 23rd of 51.

11%

Int. share of grad students, 2024

U.S. **17%** · **31st** of 51 · +2.7 pp since 2015

14%

Int. share of all master's, 2025

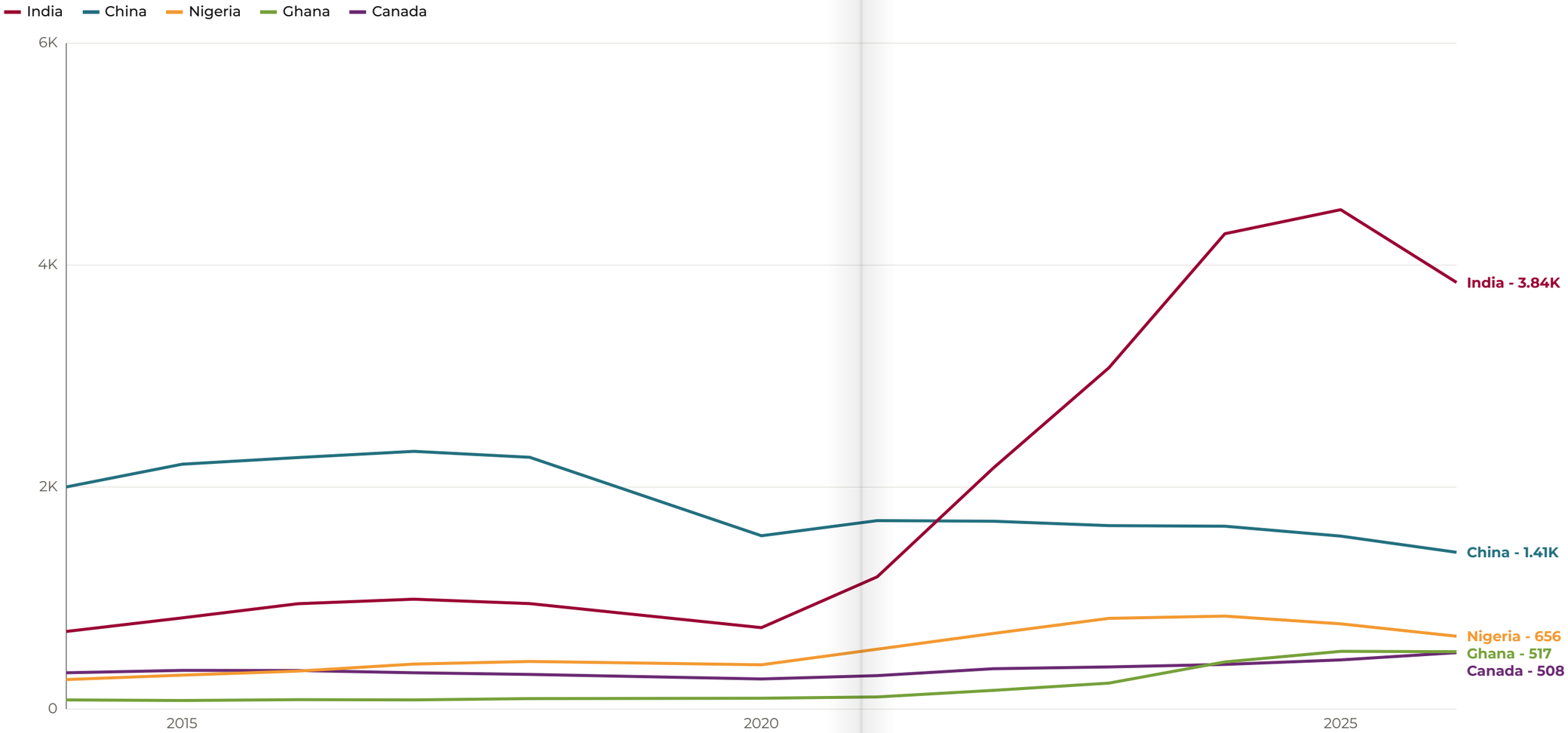
U.S. **22%** · **28th** of 51 · +7.2 pp since 2015

50%

Int. share of STEM master's, 2025

U.S. **52%** · **18th** of 51 · +27.3 pp since 2015

Figure 2 Where Do Tennessee's International Students Come From?



Active F-1 and M-1 students by country of citizenship, the five largest in October 2026; one fall snapshot per year (the month closest to November), October 2014–October 2026. All education levels. Data from DHS, SEVIS by the Numbers.

In October 2026, Tennessee had 13.7K active international students in SEVIS, 23rd of 51. India accounted for 28% of them and China for 10%, against 27% and 18% nationally.

Students came from 169 countries, but the two largest supplied 39%. The state's total is up 29% since 2015, when it stood at 10.6K.

13.7K
Active international students, October 2026
23rd of 51 · U.S. **1.19M**

28%
From India
U.S. **27%**

63%
In STEM fields
U.S. **63%**

SECTION 1 · INTERNATIONAL DEPENDENCE

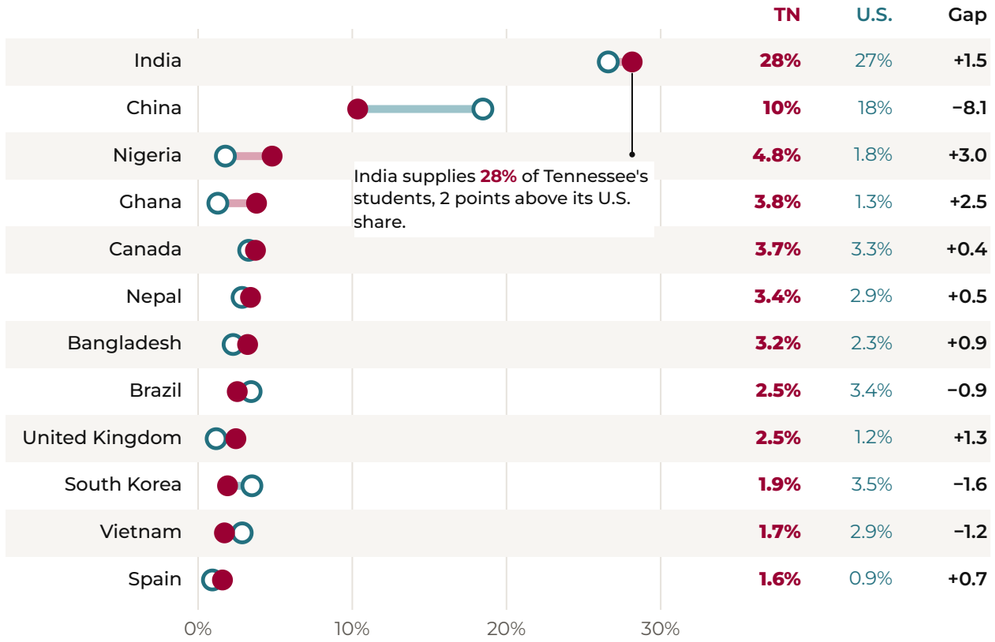
How Does Tennessee's Mix of Countries Compare With the Nation's?

In October 2026, Tennessee had **13.7K** active F-1 and M-1 students, 23rd among the 50 states and DC and **1.1%** of the U.S. total. They came from 169 countries.

India supplied **28%** of them, against 27% nationally, and China **10%**, against 18%. Nigeria (4.8%), Ghana (3.8%), and Canada (3.7%) followed.

Together the two largest countries supplied **38%** of the state's international students (U.S. 45%), 28th among the states, against 43% in 2015.

Figure 3 Is Tennessee's Mix of Countries Like the Nation's?



Share of active F-1 and M-1 students, all levels. Data from DHS, SEVIS by the Numbers, October 2026.

13.7K
Active international students, October 2026
23rd of 51 · U.S. **1.19M**

28%
From India
U.S. **27%**

10%
From China
U.S. **18%**

169
Countries represented
U.S. **219**

The state's count is down 4.9% from 2025 and up 29% since 2015, when it stood at 10.6K. Its share of all U.S. international students is up 0.3 points since 2015, to **1.1%**.

Since 2015, the number of students from India went from 822 to 3.84K, China's from 2.21K to 1.41K, and Nigeria's from 306 to 656.

Over the same years, the number from Ghana went from 77 to 517 and Canada's from 349 to 508. The table gives each country's count for the first, previous and latest years.

Table 1 International Students in Tennessee, 2015–2026

	2015	2025	2026	Change since 2015	U.S. 2026	Rank
ALL INTERNATIONAL STUDENTS						
Active F-1 and M-1 students	10.6K	14.4K	**13.7K**	+29%	1.19M	23rd
Share of U.S. active F-1/M-1 students	0.9%	1.1%	**1.1%**	+0.3 pp	–	23rd
Countries of citizenship represented	158	173	**169**	+7.0%	219	22nd
Share from the two largest countries of origin	43%	42%	**38%**	−4.9 pp	45%	28th
LARGEST COUNTRIES OF CITIZENSHIP (STUDENTS)					**U.S. SHARE**	**STATE SHARE**
India	822	4.5K	**3.84K**	+368%	27%	28%
China	2.21K	1.56K	**1.41K**	−36%	18%	10%
Nigeria	306	768	**656**	+114%	1.8%	4.8%
Ghana	77	520	**517**	+571%	1.3%	3.8%
Canada	349	443	**508**	+46%	3.3%	3.7%

Active F-1 and M-1 students, one fall snapshot per year (the month closest to November; 2019 has none; the latest year is October 2026). Rank among the 50 states and DC. Data from DHS, SEVIS by the Numbers.

Figure 4

Which Countries Supply Tennessee's International STEM Students?

8.64K of Tennessee's international students were in STEM fields in October 2026, **63%** of the total against 63% nationally, up 99% since 2015.

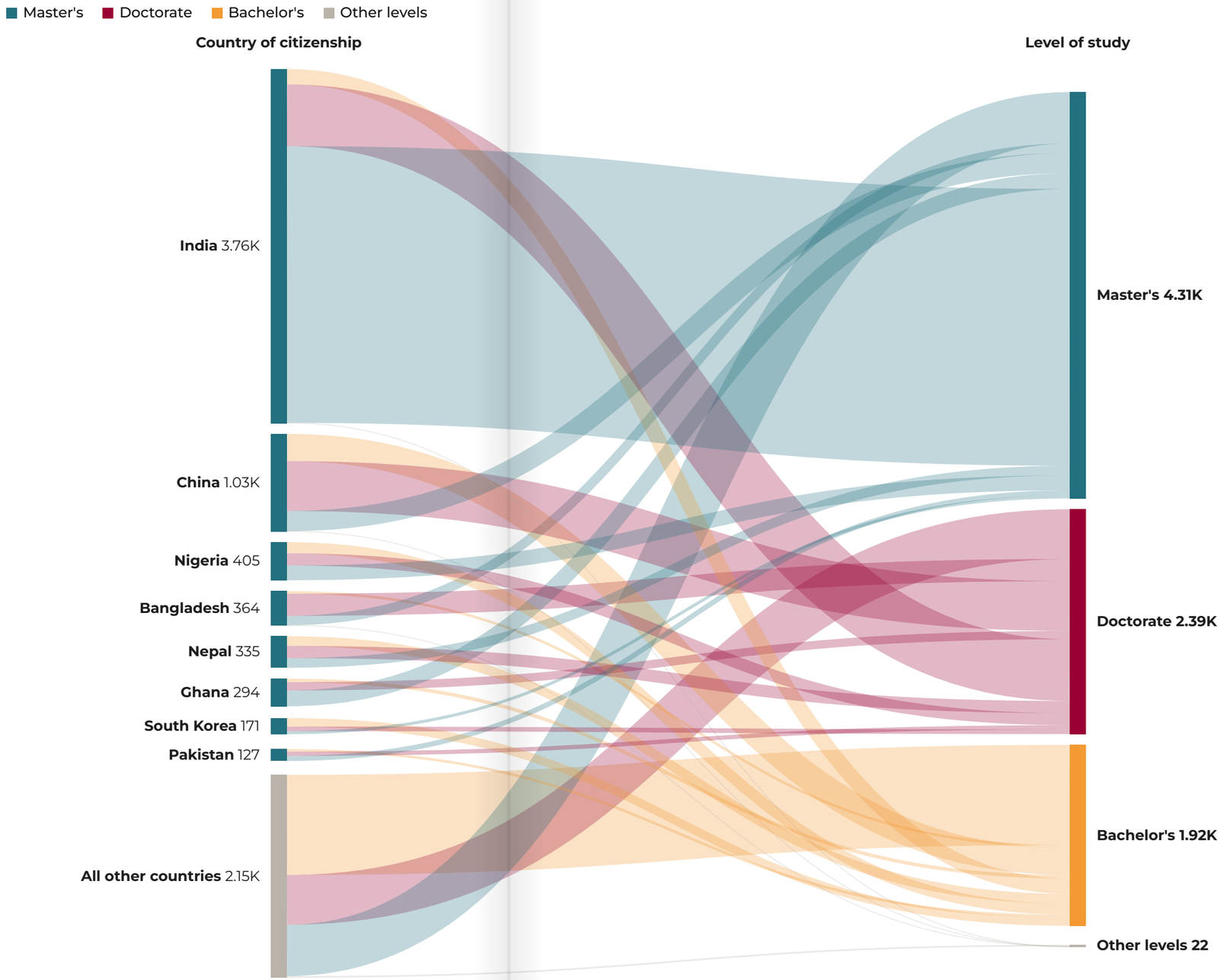
Master's students were the largest group, **4.31K**. India supplied 68% of them and China 5.0%.

STEM doctoral students went from 1.35K in 2015 to **2.39K**, and STEM master's students from 907 to 4.31K.

8.64K
Active STEM F-1/M-1 students, 2026
U.S. **749K** · **22nd** of 51 · +99% since 2015

63%
Share in STEM fields
U.S. **63%**

4.31K
Active STEM master's students, 2026
U.S. **393K** · **20th** of 51 · 4.75× since 2015



Active F-1 and M-1 students in STEM fields by country of citizenship and level of study, October 2026; the eight largest countries are shown. Data from DHS, SEVIS by the Numbers, October 2026.

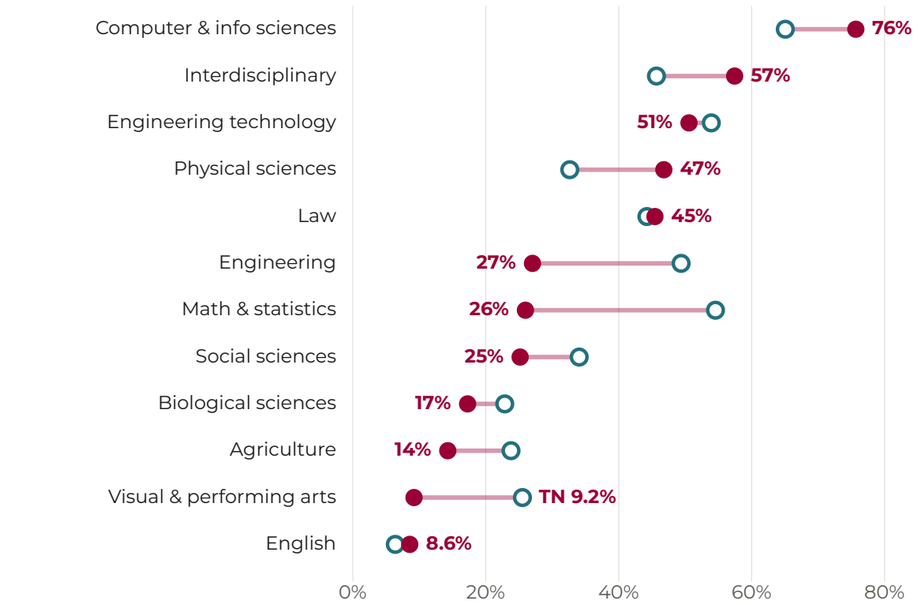
SECTION 1 · INTERNATIONAL DEPENDENCE

How International Are Tennessee's Master's Fields?

Each row is a master's field with at least 30 graduates in Tennessee in 2025, ranked by the share of degrees earned by international students (U.S. nonresidents on temporary visas). The filled dot is the state's share; the open dot is the national share for the same field.

Highest international shares. International students earned the largest shares of master's degrees in computer & info sciences (76%, against 65% for the U.S.), interdisciplinary (57%, against 46% for the U.S.), and engineering technology (51%, against 54% for the U.S.).

Figure 5 Which Master's Fields Depend Most on International Students?



International share of master's degrees by field, 2025; fields with 30+ graduates. Data from NCES, IPEDS Completions.

14%
Int. share of all master's, 2025
U.S. **22%** · **28th** of 51

50%
Int. share of STEM master's, 2025
U.S. **52%** · **18th** of 51

76%
Int. share of CS master's, 2025
U.S. **65%** · **14th** of 47

The table gives the international share of degrees in each STEM field at three levels: Tennessee first, the United States after the slash. The master's column is highlighted. A dash means the state awarded no degrees in the field at that level.

Highest international share among STEM master's fields. International students earned 76% of the master's degrees in computer & info sciences, against 65% for the U.S.

Fields with an international majority. International students earned more than half of the master's degrees in 2 STEM fields.

Table 2 How International Is Each STEM Field?

Field	Bachelor's	Master's	Doctorates
Computer & info sciences	7.3% / 8.6%	**76% / 65%**	59% / 56%
Engineering	3.4% / 7.2%	**27% / 49%**	47% / 55%
Engineering technology	1.1% / 4.5%	**51% / 54%**	– / 42%
Math & statistics	7.9% / 17%	**26% / 55%**	47% / 53%
Physical sciences	3.9% / 6.0%	**47% / 33%**	33% / 38%
Biological sciences	2.9% / 3.4%	**17% / 23%**	19% / 23%
Natural resources	0.4% / 2.0%	**8.8% / 17%**	– / 27%
Architecture	0.5% / 7.3%	**13% / 29%**	– / 55%

International share in Tennessee / U.S., 2025. Data from NCES, IPEDS Completions.

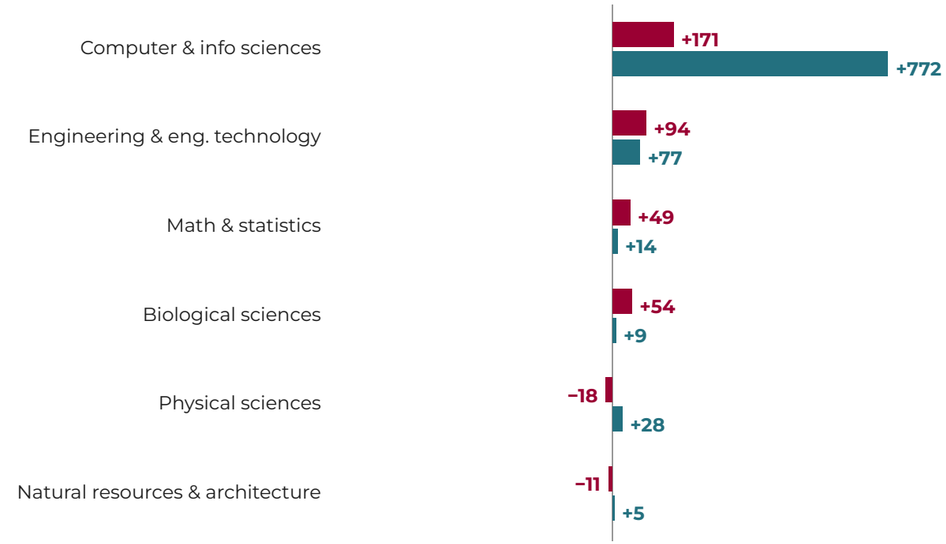
SECTION 1 · INTERNATIONAL DEPENDENCE

How Has Tennessee's STEM Master's Output Grown?

Each pair of bars is the change in the number of STEM master's degrees awarded in Tennessee between 2015 and 2025 in one field: to domestic students (U.S. citizens and permanent residents) and to international students. Bars to the left of the axis are declines.

STEM master's degrees. The state awarded 2.29K in 2025 and 1.05K in 2015, a change of +905 for international students and +339 for domestic students.

Figure 6 Where Did the STEM Master's Growth Come From?



Change in STEM master's degrees by field, 2015–2025. Data from NCES, IPEDS Completions.

1.14K
International STEM master's, 2025
U.S. **117K** · **23rd** of 51

16%
STEM share of master's, 2025
U.S. **23%** · **38th** of 51

1.0%
Share of U.S. international STEM master's, 2025
23rd of 51

4.1
STEM master's per STEM research doctorate, 2025
U.S. **6.4** · **38th** of 51

The table gives the number of STEM master's degrees awarded in Tennessee in each field in 2015 and 2025, the change between the two years, the number awarded to international students in 2025, and international students' share of the field's degrees in each year.

STEM share of master's degrees. The share was 16% in 2025, against 23% for the U.S., 38th among the states, up 0.2 points from 16% in 2024 and up 7.5 points since 2015, when it was 8.9%.

Table 3 How Many STEM Master's Degrees Does Each Field Award?

Field	2015	2025	Change	International 2025	Int. share 2015	Int. share 2025
Computer & info sciences	138	**1.08K**	+683%	818	33%	76%
Engineering & eng. technology	371	**542**	+46%	167	24%	31%
Math & statistics	91	**154**	+69%	40	29%	26%
Biological sciences	267	**330**	+24%	57	18%	17%
Physical sciences	99	**109**	+10%	51	23%	47%
Natural resources & architecture	80	**74**	−7.5%	8	3.8%	11%

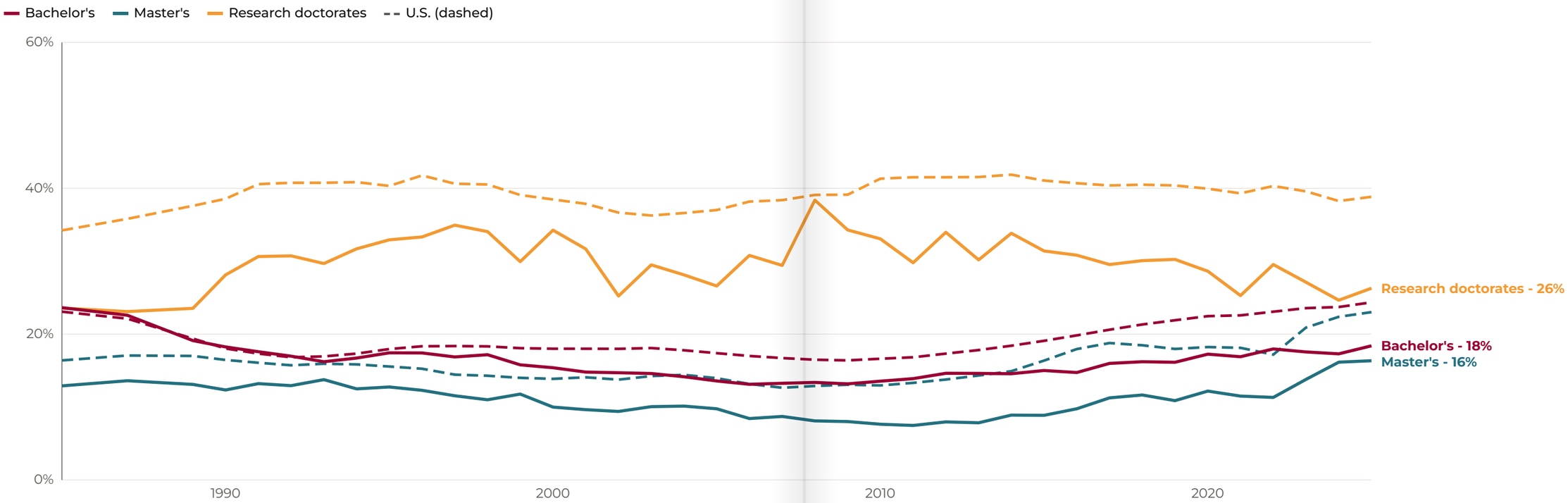
STEM master's degrees awarded in Tennessee, all students and international students, 2015 and 2025. Data from NCES, IPEDS Completions.

SECTION 2

STEM Degrees

Tennessee ranks 44th of 51 on the STEM share of bachelor's, at 18% in 2025 against 24% for the U.S.

Figure 7 How Much of Tennessee's Degree Output Is STEM?



STEM share of degrees by level; state solid, U.S. dashed. Data from NCES, IPEDS Completions.

STEM fields account for 18% of Tennessee's bachelor's degrees, 16% of its master's and 26% of its research doctorates (U.S. 24%, 23% and 39%).

The STEM share of master's degrees is up 7.5 points since 2015, and the state ranks 38th of 51 on it. On the STEM share of bachelor's degrees it ranks 44th of 51.

18%

STEM share of bachelor's, 2025

U.S. **24%** · **44th** of 51 · +3.4 pp since 2015

16%

STEM share of master's, 2025

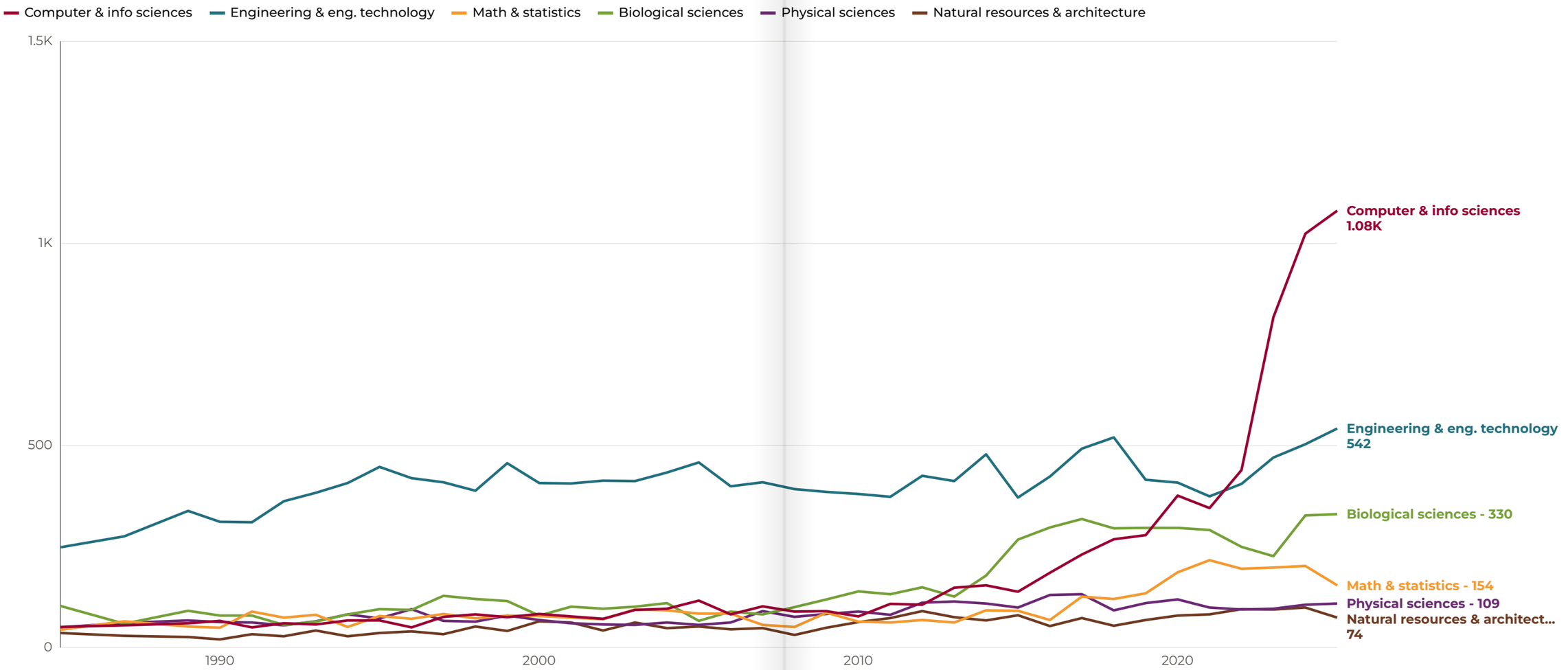
U.S. **23%** · **38th** of 51 · +7.5 pp since 2015

26%

STEM share of research doctorates, 2025

U.S. **39%** · **44th** of 51 · −5.1 pp since 2015

Figure 8 Which STEM Fields Produce Tennessee's Master's Degrees?



STEM master's degrees by field, all students. Data from NCES, IPEDS Completions.

Computer & info sciences produced the most STEM master's degrees in 2025, 1.08K, followed by engineering & eng. technology (542) and biological sciences (330). Master's degrees in computer & info sciences are up 683% since 2015.

International students earned 1.14K of the state's STEM master's degrees in 2025, 1.0% of the national total (23rd of 51).

1.14K

International STEM master's, 2025

U.S. **117K** · **23rd** of 51 · 4.83× since 2015

1.0%

Share of U.S. international STEM master's, 2025

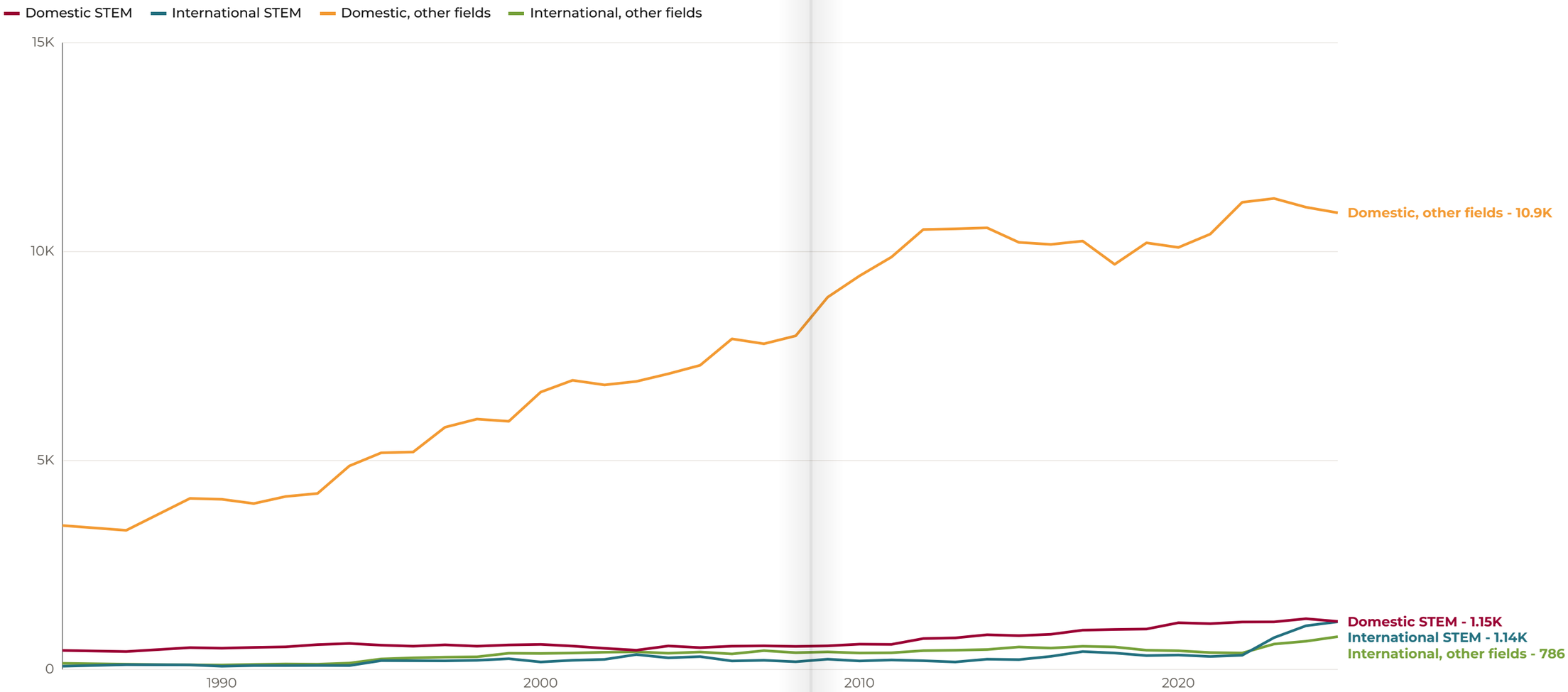
23rd of 51 · +0.5 pp since 2015

76%

Int. share of CS master's, 2025

U.S. **65%** · **14th** of 47 · +42.3 pp since 2015

Figure 9 Who Earns Tennessee's Master's Degrees?



Master's degrees by student residency and field group. Data from NCES, IPEDS Completions.

Between 2015 and 2025, 905 more STEM master's degrees went to international students and 339 more to domestic students.

International students earn 50% of Tennessee's STEM master's but 6.7% of master's in other fields (U.S. 52% and 12%).

14%

Int. share of all master's, 2025
U.S. **22%** · **28th** of 51 · +7.2 pp since 2015

50%

Int. share of STEM master's, 2025
U.S. **52%** · **18th** of 51 · +27.3 pp since 2015

4.1

STEM master's per STEM research doctorate (IPEDS), 2025
U.S. **6.4** · **38th** of 51 · +1.7 since 2015

SECTION 3

Where Students Come From

Tennessee ranks 41st of 51 on the share of first-time students whose home is outside the US, at 1.6% in 2024 against 3.1% for the U.S.

Figure 10 First-Time Students by Home and Destination, Fall 2024



Home of first-time degree-seeking undergraduates (left) and the state of the institution entered (right); the five largest sources and destinations (more when states tie at the printed figure), the rest grouped; ties are ordered by exact count. Data from NCES, IPEDS Fall Enrollment.

41K residents stayed in Tennessee for college in fall 2024; 11.7K students arrived from other states and 848 from abroad, while 11.4K residents left.

Each band runs from a student's home on the left to the state where they enrolled on the right. 76% of the state's first-time students are residents.

76%

First-time students from in state, 2024

19th of 51 · −4.9 pp since 2016

1.6%

First-time students from abroad, 2024

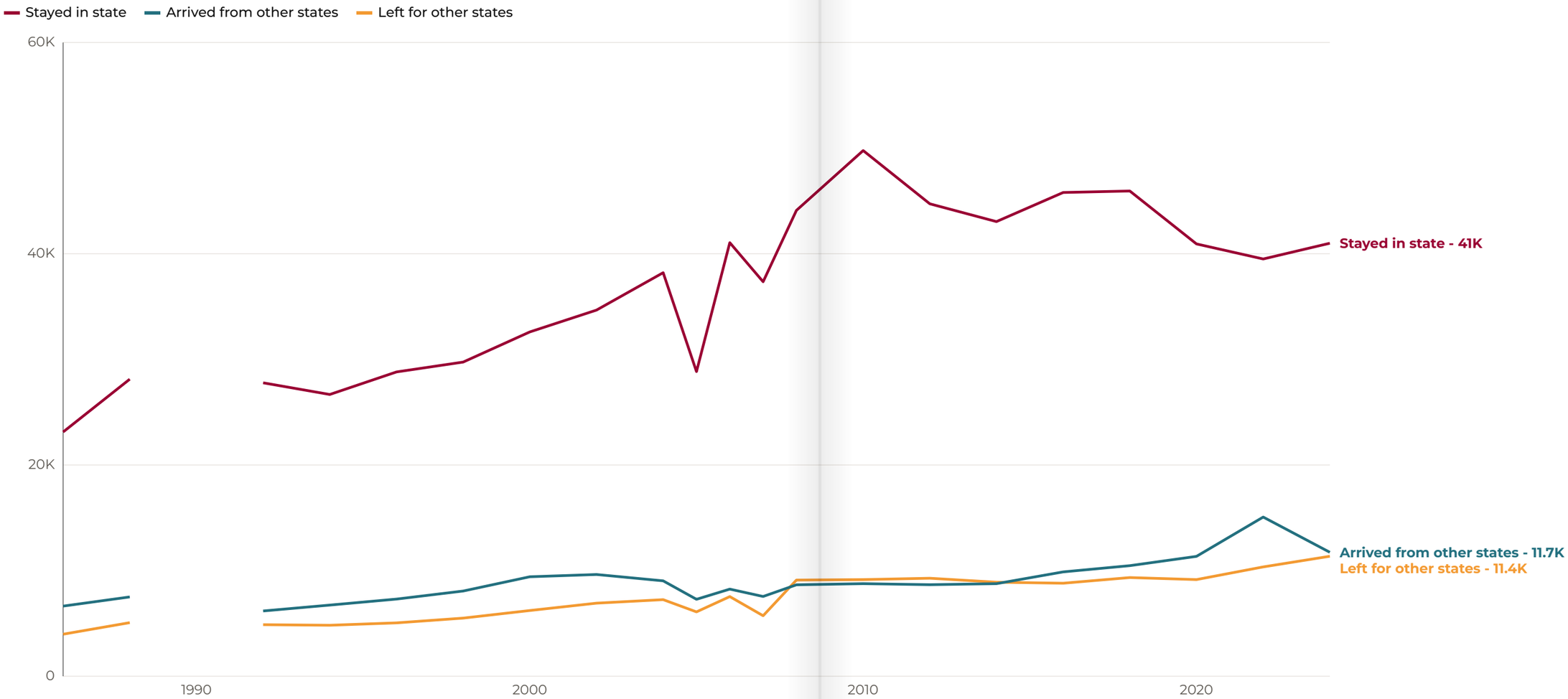
U.S. **3.1%** · **41st** of 51 · +0.3 pp since 2016

+1

Net migration per 100 residents, 2024

34th of 51 · −1.3 since 2016

Figure 11 How Have the Flows Changed?



First-time degree-seeking undergraduates by flow; even years before 2001. Data from NCES, IPEDS Fall Enrollment.

Since 2015, the number of residents staying in state for college is down 10%, arrivals from other states are up 19%, and residents leaving are up 29%.

Net migration was +1 per 100 resident first-time students (34th of 51). The top destination for residents who left was Alabama (1.58K).

Figure 12

Where Do Tennessee's Newcomers Come From?

The bands show where first-time degree-seeking undergraduates who enrolled at Tennessee's institutions in fall 2024 but did not live in the state came from: the 12 largest home states and students from abroad, with all other states grouped. Band widths are proportional to the number of students. Home is the state where the student lived when admitted.

12.6K

First-time students from other states and abroad, fall 2024

Abroad **848**

1.6%

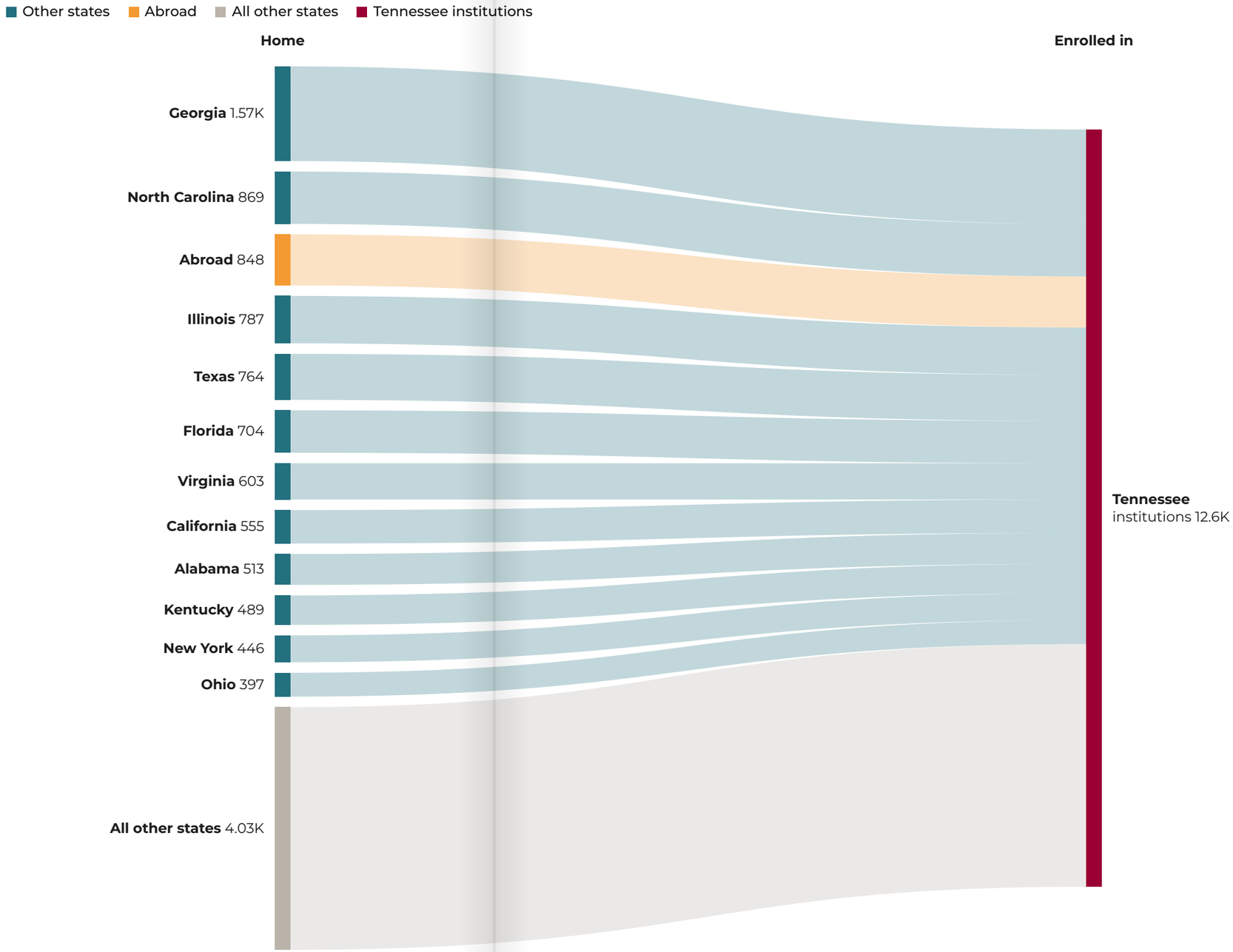
First-time students from abroad, 2024

U.S. **3.1%** · **41st** of 51 · +0.3 pp since 2016

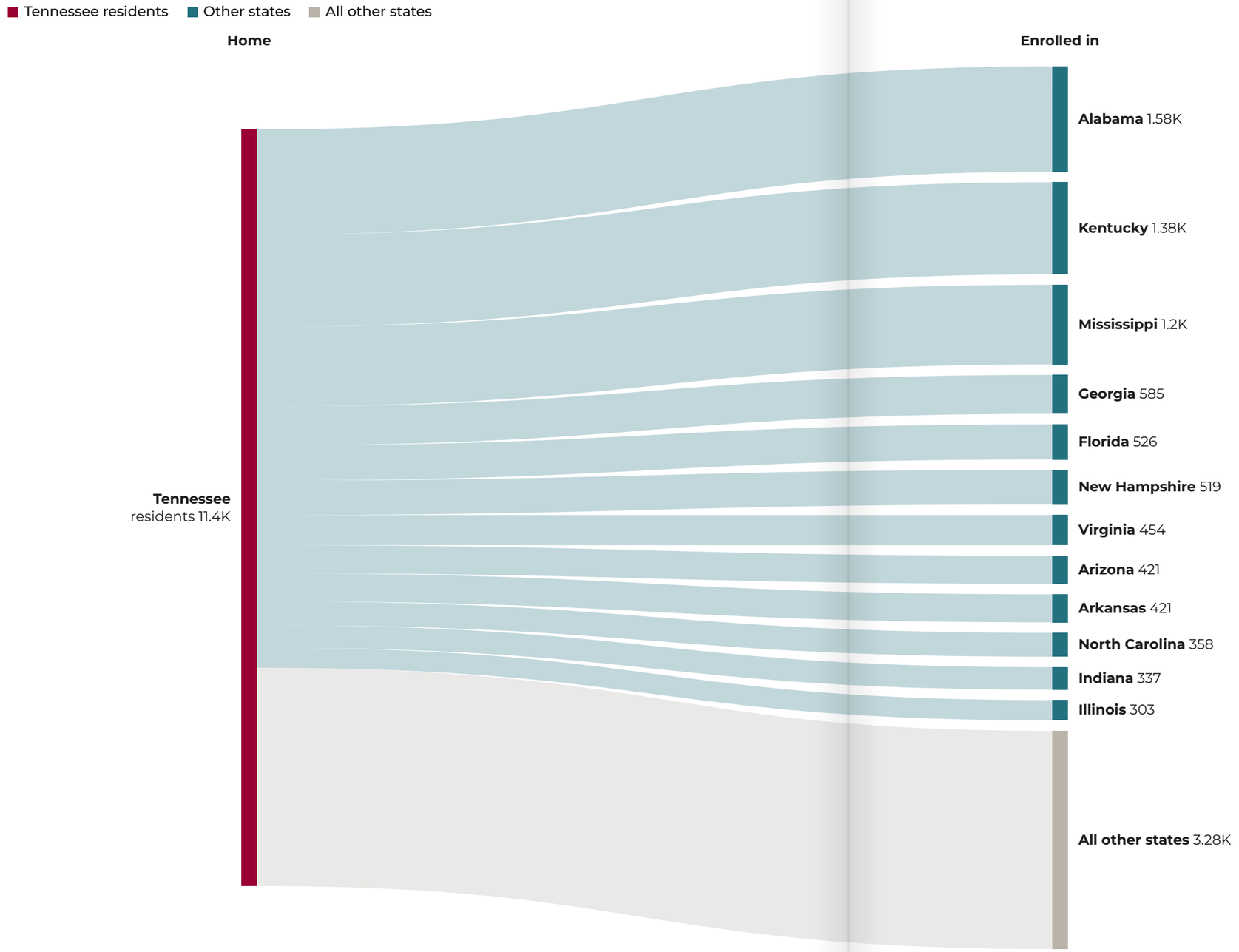
76%

First-time students from in state, 2024

19th of 51 · −4.9 pp since 2016



First-time degree-seeking undergraduates, fall 2024; the 12 largest flows (more when states tie at the printed figure), ordered by exact count. Data from NCES, IPEDS Fall Enrollment.



First-time degree-seeking undergraduates, fall 2024; the 12 largest flows (more when states tie at the printed figure), ordered by exact count. Data from NCES, IPEDS Fall Enrollment.

Figure 13

Where Do Tennessee's Residents Go When They Leave?

The bands show where Tennessee residents who left the state to start college in fall 2024 enrolled: the 12 largest destination states, with all other states grouped. Band widths are proportional to the number of students. Residents who enrolled in the state are not shown.

Residents leaving for other states. The number was 11.4K in fall 2024, up 9.8% from 10.3K in fall 2022 and up 29% since fall 2016, when it was 8.8K.

11.4K
Residents who started college in another state, fall 2024
Arrived from other states **11.7K** · **12.6K** with abroad

+1
Net migration per 100 residents, 2024
34th of 51 · −1.3 since 2016

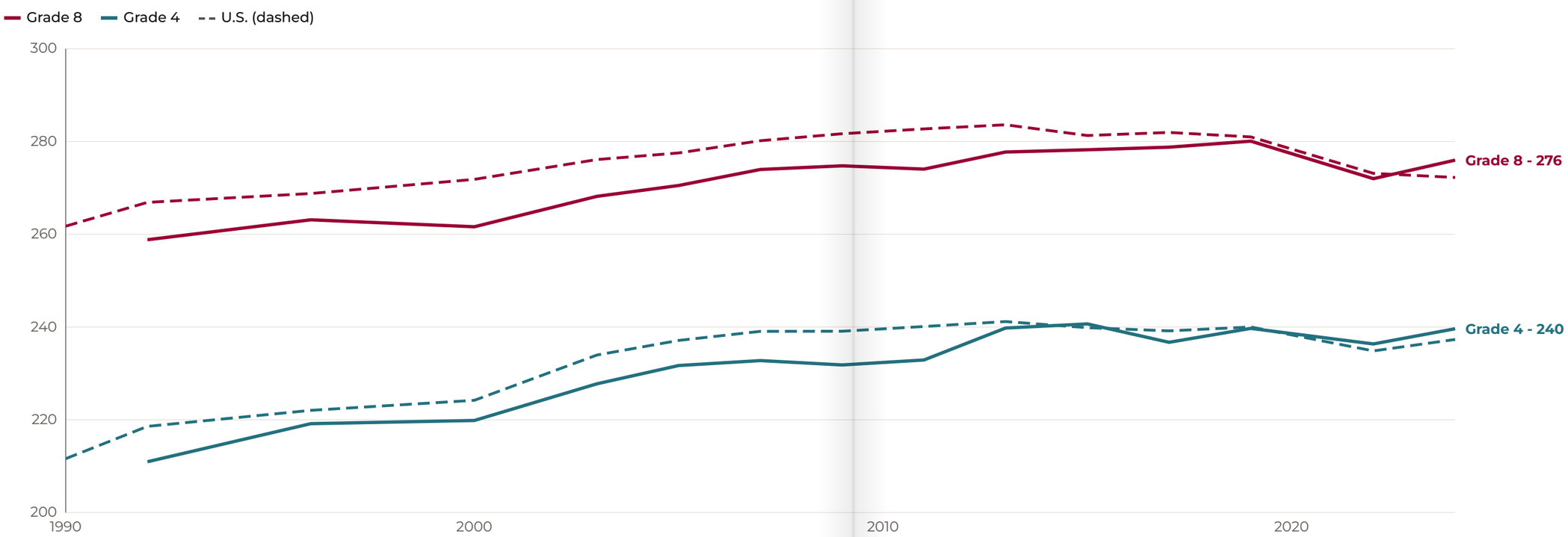
1.58K
Went to Alabama
The largest destination

SECTION 4

K-12 Preparation

Tennessee ranks 18th of 51 on the share of grade 8 mathematics: at or above Proficient, at 31% in 2024 against 27% for the U.S.

Figure 14 How Well Prepared in Mathematics Are Tennessee's Students?



Average NAEP mathematics score, public schools, 0–500 scale; state solid, U.S. public schools dashed. Data from NCES, National Assessment of Educational Progress.

The talent pipeline starts in school. Tennessee's eighth graders averaged 276 in mathematics on the 2024 NAEP, against 272 for U.S. public schools, 19th of 51 among the states.

31% scored at or above the Proficient level (U.S. 27%). Differences of a point or two are often within the margin of error.

276

Grade 8 math score (NAEP), 2024

U.S. **272** · **19th** of 51 · −2.2 since 2015

31%

Grade 8 math, at or above Proficient, 2024

U.S. **27%** · **18th** of 51 · +1.3 pp since 2015

259

Grade 8 reading score (NAEP), 2024

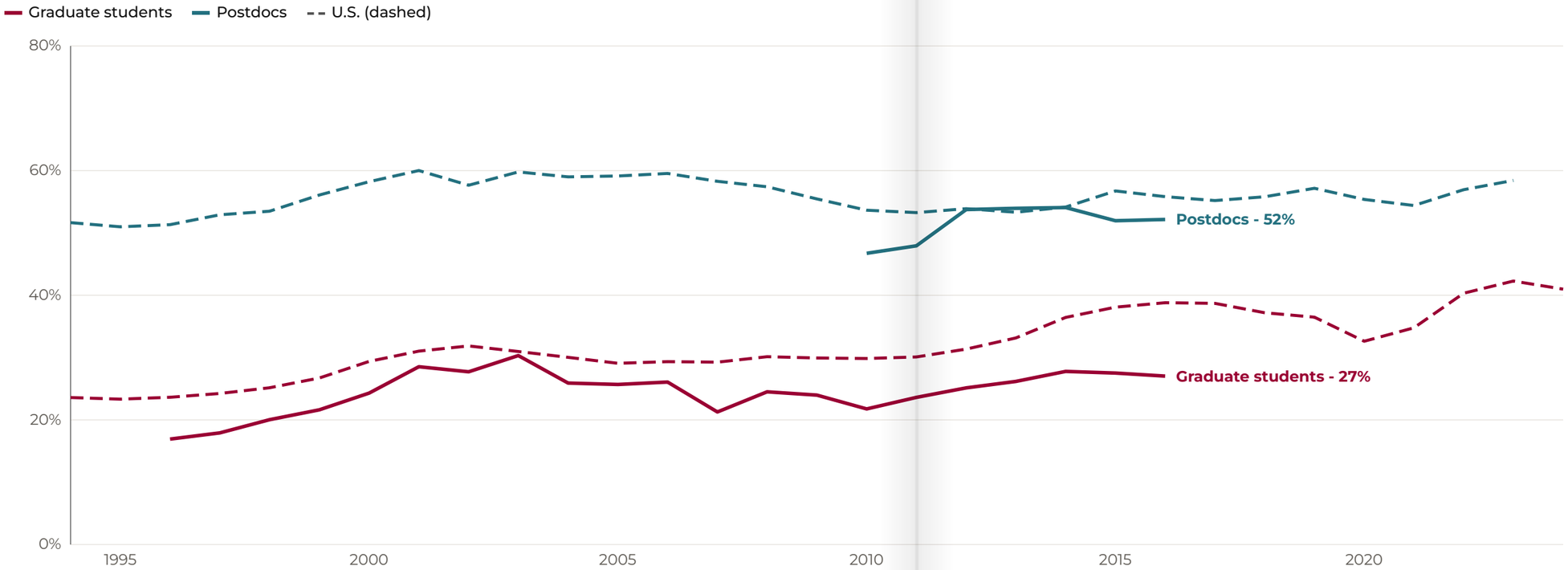
U.S. **257** · **20th** of 51 · −5.8 since 2015

SECTION 5

Graduate Research

Tennessee ranks 39th of 51 on the temporary-visa share of S&E graduate students, at 27% in 2016 against 39% for the U.S.

Figure 15 How Many of Tennessee's Science and Engineering Graduate Students Hold Temporary Visas?



Temporary-visa share of science and engineering graduate students and postdoctoral appointees, by the institution's state; state solid, U.S. dashed. NSF stopped publishing state tables after 2016. Data from NSF NCSES, Survey of Graduate Students and Postdoctorates.

In 2016, the last year NSF published state tables, 27% of Tennessee's science and engineering graduate students held temporary visas (U.S. 39%; 39th of 51).

Among postdoctoral researchers, the share was 52% (U.S. 56%). Postdocs are the stage of research training most dependent on international talent, and IPEDS does not count them.

The state's institutions awarded 1.01K research doctorates in 2025, 1.7% of the U.S. total (Data from NSF NCSES, Survey of Earned Doctorates; NSF publishes doctorates by citizenship only for the nation).

27%
S&E grad students on temporary visas, 2016
U.S. **39%** · **39th** of 51 · −0.5 pp since 2015

52%
S&E postdocs on temporary visas, 2016
U.S. **56%** · **30th** of 51 · +0.2 pp since 2015

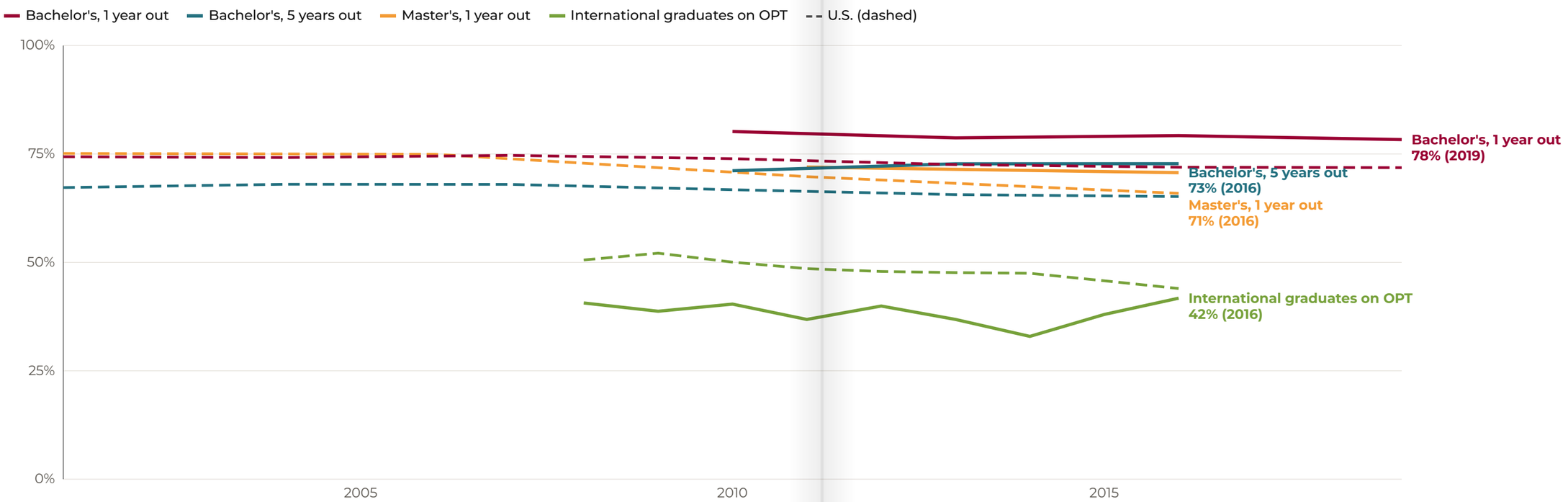
1.01K
Research doctorates awarded (NSF SED), 2025
U.S. **59K** · **20th** of 51 · +13% since 2015

SECTION 6

Do Graduates Stay?

Tennessee ranks 5th of 33 on the share of bachelor's graduates working in the state 1 year after graduating, at 78% in 2019 against 72% for the U.S.

Figure 16 How Many of Tennessee's Graduates Go On to Work in the State?



Share of employed graduates working in the state of their institution, by graduating cohort (Data from U.S. Census Bureau, Post-Secondary Employment Outcomes; participating institutions only); international graduates' OPT jobs in the state where they studied (Data from ICE, SEVIS FOIA releases; shares only, the file is truncated). State solid, U.S. or participating states dashed.

Of Tennessee's bachelor's graduates who were working a year after graduating, 78% worked in the state (participating states 72%). Five years out the share was 73%.

Among international graduates on Optional Practical Training in 2016, 42% worked in the state where they studied (U.S. 44%). That is the last year the released records cover, before most of the growth in international STEM master's degrees since 2015. Through migration between states, the state gained 0.5 bachelor's-plus adults per 1,000 such residents in 2025 (Data from U.S. Census Bureau, American Community Survey).

78%

Bachelor's grads working in-state, 1 year out, 2019

U.S. **72%** · **5th** of 33 · −0.9 pp since 2016

42%

OPT graduates working in the state, 2016

U.S. **44%** · **19th** of 51 · +3.7 pp since 2015

+0.5

Net migration, bachelor's-plus, per 1,000, 2025

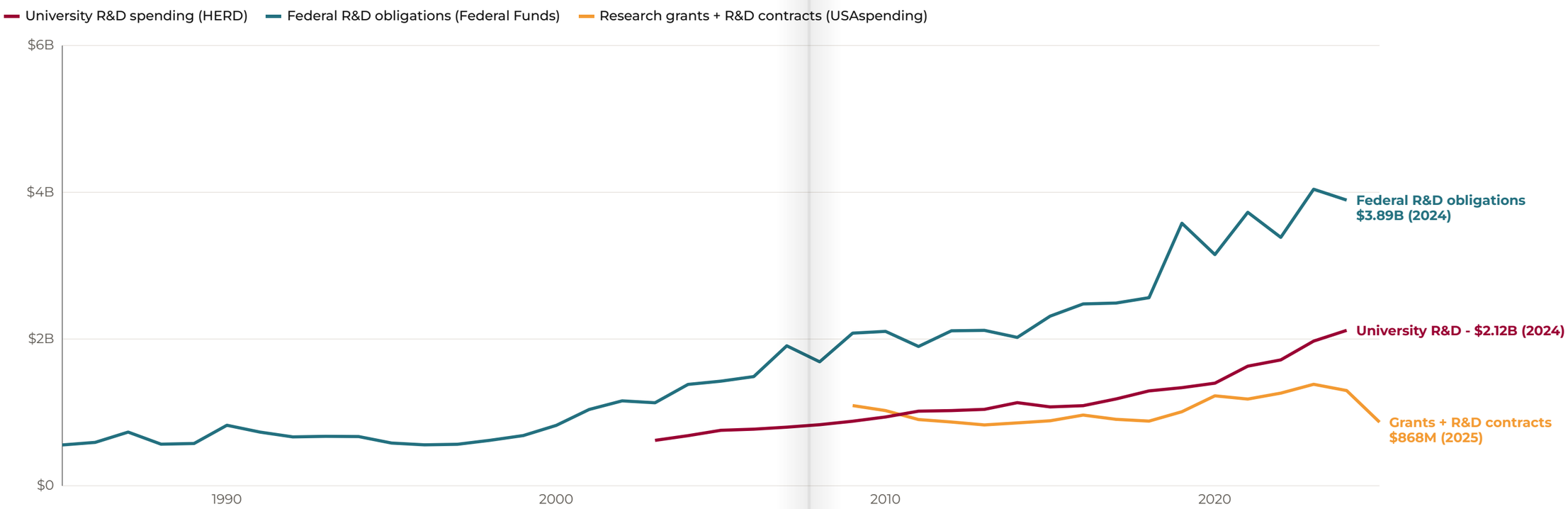
28th of 51 · −5.8 since 2015

SECTION 7

Research Funding

Tennessee ranks 15th of 51 on federal R&D obligations to the state, at $3.89B in 2024 against $193B for the U.S.

Figure 17 How Much Research Money Flows Into Tennessee?



Nominal dollars (not adjusted for inflation), fiscal years; a line ending before the others is labeled with its last year. University R&D: Data from NSF NCSES, Higher Education Research and Development Survey (FY2003-09 predecessor survey). Federal R&D obligations by state of performance: Data from NSF NCSES, Survey of Federal Funds for R&D (coverage widens in FY2021). Grants from NSF, NIH, NASA and DOE Science plus R&D contracts: Data from USAspending.gov.

Tennessee's universities spent $2.12B on research and development in FY2024, 18th of 51 among the states; 55% of it was federally funded (U.S. 55%).

Federal agencies obligated $3.89B for R&D performed in the state in FY2024. Research funding drives demand for graduate students and postdocs, the stage of training most dependent on international talent.

$2.12B

University R&D spending, 2024

U.S. **$118B** · **18th** of 51 · +97% since 2015

55%

Federal share of university R&D, 2024

U.S. **55%** · **19th** of 51 · −3.0 pp since 2015

$3.89B

Federal R&D obligations, 2024

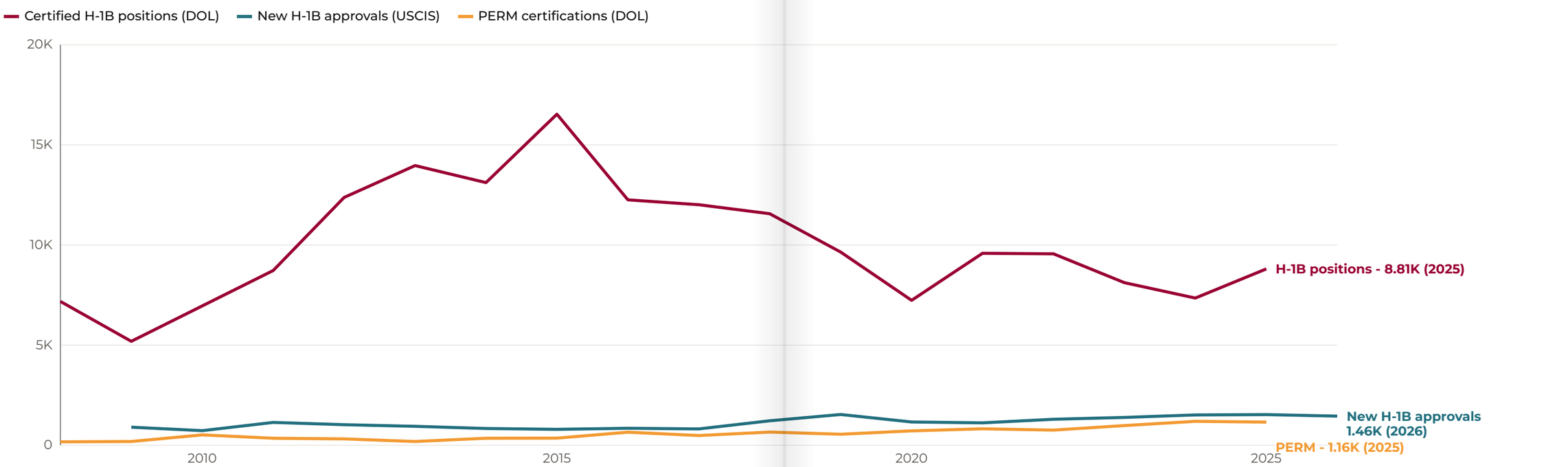
U.S. **$193B** · **15th** of 51 · +68% since 2015

SECTION 8

H-1B Jobs and Green Cards

Tennessee ranks 19th of 51 on certified H-1B positions, by worksite, at 8.81K in 2025 against 914K for the U.S.

Figure 18 How Many Skilled-Visa Jobs and Green-Card Certifications Does Tennessee Generate?



Certified H-1B positions on labor condition applications by worksite and certified PERM green-card applications, by fiscal year (Data from DOL, Office of Foreign Labor Certification); new H-1B petition approvals by the employer's address (Data from USCIS, H-1B Employer Data Hub).

Employers were certified for 8.81K H-1B positions at Tennessee worksites in FY2025, 19th of 51 among the states. A labor condition application comes before the petition and covers renewals and job changes as well as new hires, by the worksite's state, so it runs well above approvals. USCIS approved 1.46K new H-1B petitions in FY2026 and 3.65K continuing ones, counted by the employer's address.

DOL certified 1.16K PERM applications, the employer's step toward an employment-based green card, for jobs in the state in FY2025. In FY2024, 9.6% were for workers still on F-1 student visas (U.S. 8.7%): the most direct link from classroom to permanent residence.

8.81K

Certified H-1B positions (worksite), 2025

U.S. **914K** · **19th** of 51 · −47% since 2015

1.16K

PERM green-card certifications, 2025

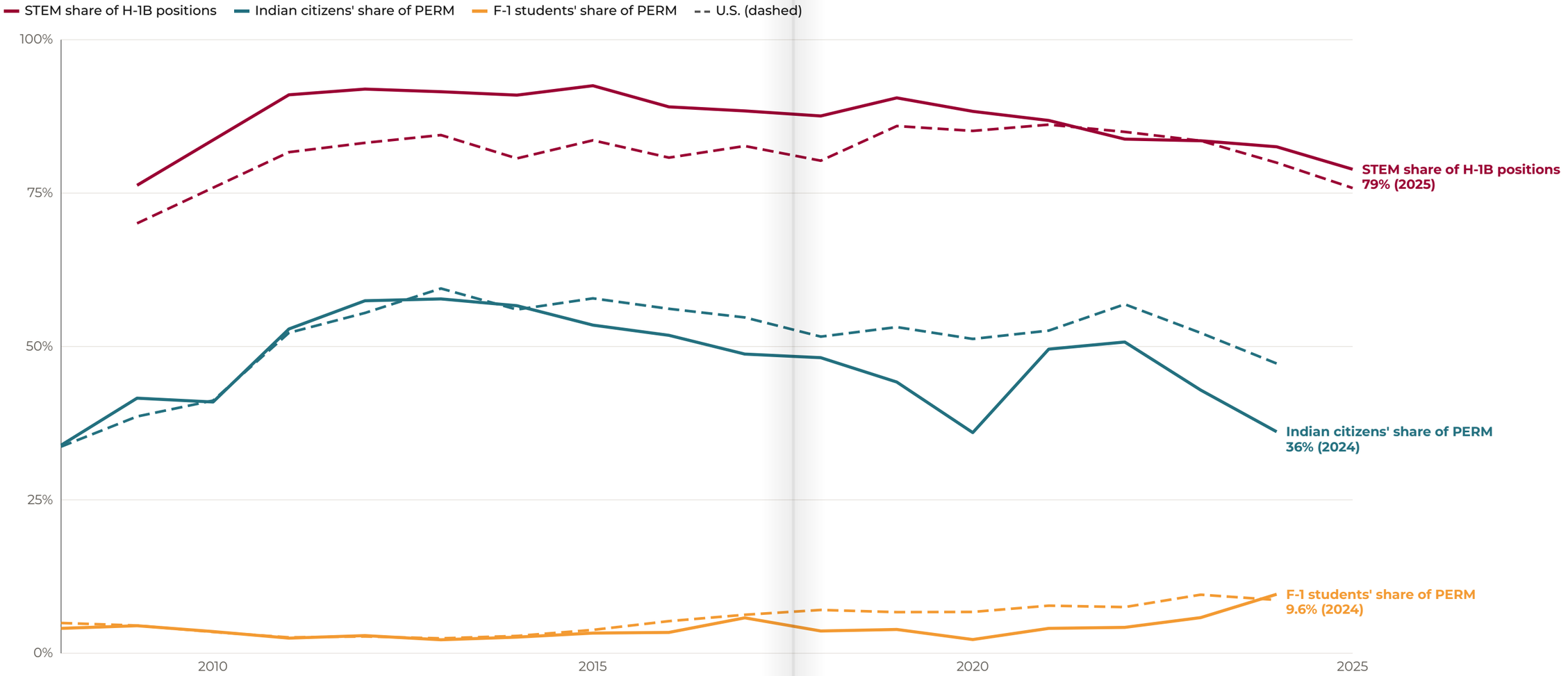
U.S. **138K** · **24th** of 51 · 3.23× since 2015

9.6%

PERM workers on F-1 student visas, 2024

U.S. **8.7%** · **26th** of 51 · +6.3 pp since 2015

Figure 19 Who Holds Tennessee's Skilled-Visa Jobs?



State solid, U.S. dashed. PERM citizenship and class of admission are not on the form DOL uses from FY2025. Data from DOL, Office of Foreign Labor Certification.

79% of the state's certified H-1B positions were in STEM occupations in FY2025 (U.S. 76%).

Citizens of India held 36% of the state's PERM certifications in FY2024 (U.S. 47%). Under per-country caps they face the longest waits for a green card, so this share measures the state's exposure to the backlog.

79%

STEM share of H-1B positions, 2025

U.S. **76%** · **12th** of 51 · −13.6 pp since 2015

36%

PERM certifications for Indian citizens, 2024

U.S. **47%** · **26th** of 51 · −17.4 pp since 2015

$99.7K

Median offered H-1B wage (nominal), 2025

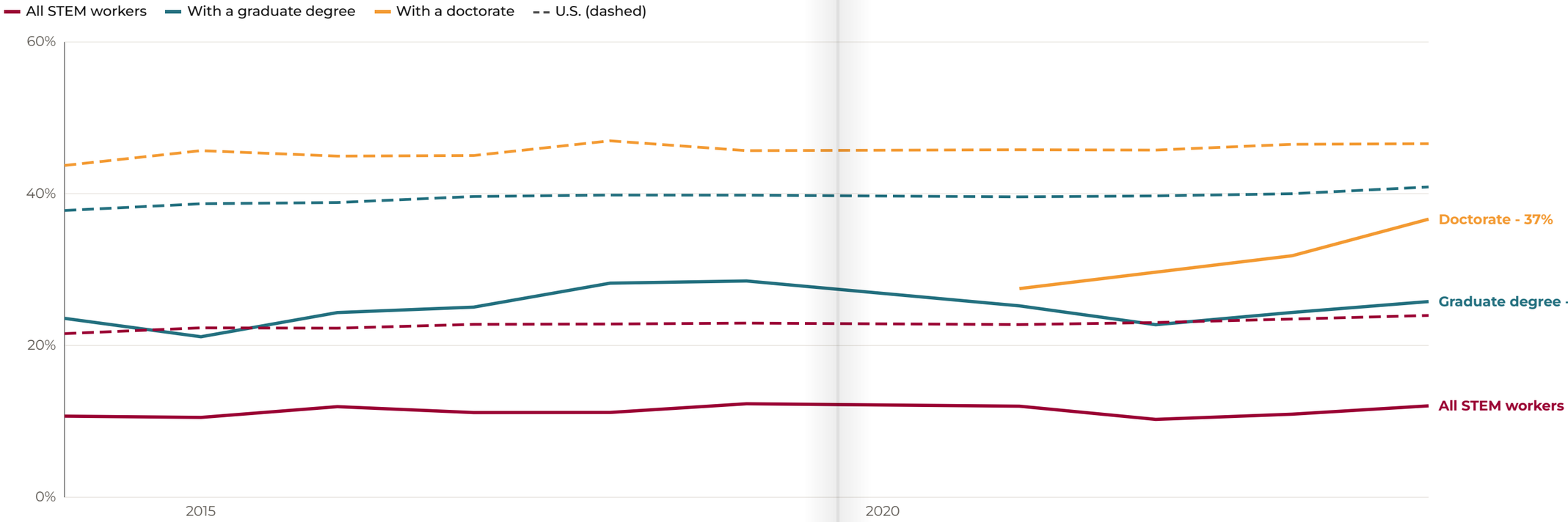
U.S. **$119K** · **30th** of 51 · +47% since 2015

SECTION 9

STEM Workforce

Tennessee ranks 27th of 44 on the foreign-born share of STEM workers with a graduate degree, at 26% in 2024 against 41% for the U.S.

Figure 20 How Much of Tennessee's STEM Workforce Was Born Abroad?



Foreign-born share of employed workers in STEM occupations, by state of residence; state solid, U.S. dashed. Shares resting on fewer than 100 survey records are left out. No 2020 (experimental data). Data from U.S. Census Bureau, American Community Survey.

In 2024, 12% of the people working in STEM occupations in Tennessee were born abroad (U.S. 24%; 33rd of 51).

The share rises with education: 26% of STEM workers with a graduate degree were foreign-born (U.S. 41%), and 37% of those with a doctorate (U.S. 47%; 17th of 20). 6.7% of all STEM workers were not U.S. citizens.

12%

Foreign-born share of STEM workers, 2024

U.S. **24%** · **33rd** of 51 · +1.5 pp since 2015

26%

Foreign-born, STEM workers with grad degrees, 2024

U.S. **41%** · **27th** of 44 · +4.6 pp since 2015

6.7%

Noncitizen share of STEM workers, 2024

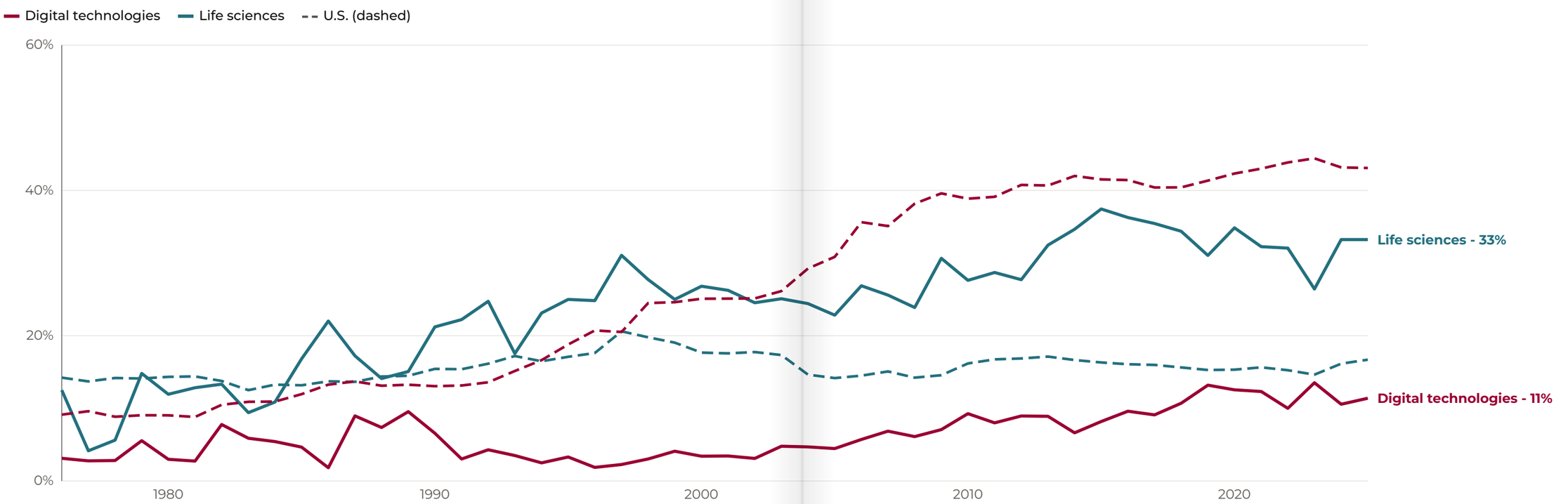
U.S. **11%** · **25th** of 51 · +1.6 pp since 2015

SECTION 10

Patents

Tennessee ranks 8th of 51 on the share of the state's patents in life sciences, at 33% in 2025 against 17% for the U.S.

Figure 21 What Kinds of Technology Does Tennessee Patent?



Share of patents granted to owners in the state, by WIPO technology field of the first classification; state solid, U.S. dashed. Fractional counts by the owner's (assignee's) location, not where inventors live. Data from USPTO, PatentsView.

Organizations and people in Tennessee were granted 984 U.S. patents in 2025, 0.7% of all patents with a U.S. owner (28th of 51).

11% were in digital technologies (U.S. 43%) and 33% in the life sciences (U.S. 17%).

984

Patents granted to owners in the state, 2025

U.S. **135K** · **28th** of 51 · +35% since 2015

11%

Patents in digital technologies, 2025

U.S. **43%** · **39th** of 51 · +3.2 pp since 2015

33%

Patents in life sciences, 2025

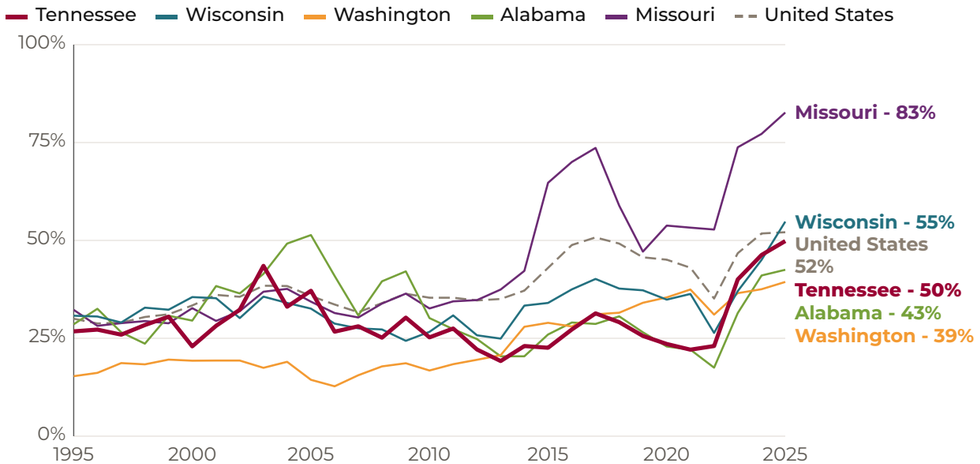
U.S. **17%** · **8th** of 51 · −4.2 pp since 2015

SECTION 11

Competitors

The four states closest in total fall enrollment, measured proportionally (a state 1.5 times as large counts as near as one two-thirds the size), are Wisconsin, Washington, Alabama, and Missouri. Tennessee ranks 3rd of the five on the international share of STEM master's; Missouri is the most dependent at 83%.

Figure 22 How Dependent Are Tennessee and Its Peers on International STEM Master's?



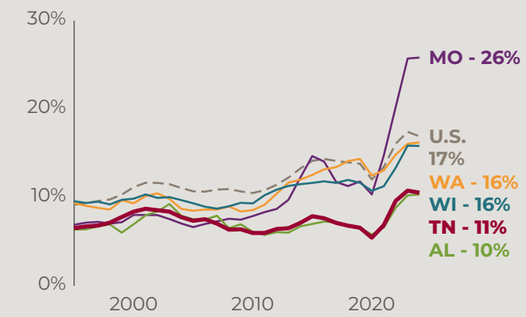
Data from NCES, IPEDS Completions.

Table 4 How Does Tennessee Compare With States of Similar Size?

Measure	TN	WI	WA	AL	MO	U.S.
Students enrolled, 2024	**325K**	328K	331K	311K	342K	19.7M
Graduate share of students, 2024	**17%**	13%	12%	18%	23%	17%
STEM share of bachelor's, 2025	**18%**	26%	32%	24%	21%	24%
STEM share of master's, 2025	**16%**	20%	28%	21%	38%	23%
International STEM master's, 2025	**1.14K**	1.29K	1.22K	1.47K	7.27K	117K
Share of U.S. international STEM master's, 2025	**1.0%**	1.1%	1.0%	1.3%	6.2%	–
Int. share of STEM master's, 2025	**50%**	55%	39%	43%	83%	52%
Int. share of STEM research doctorates, 2025	**35%**	37%	34%	49%	51%	43%
Int. share of grad students, 2024	**11%**	16%	16%	10%	26%	17%
Int. share of undergraduate enrollment, 2024	**2.0%**	2.6%	4.1%	1.5%	2.7%	3.0%
Six-year graduation rate, 2024	**58%**	67%	69%	60%	60%	65%
In-state tuition, public 4-year, 2023	**$11K**	$9.42K	$8K	$11.6K	$10.5K	$9.71K
Appropriations per student, 2024	**$12.1K**	$11.4K	$11.5K	$11.4K	$8.75K	$11.4K
Average faculty salary, 2024	**$92.8K**	$96.1K	$102K	$86.4K	$93.7K	$106K
First-time students from in state, 2024	**76%**	73%	85%	68%	74%	–
Net migration per 100 residents, 2024	**+1**	+6	−15	+23	+0	–

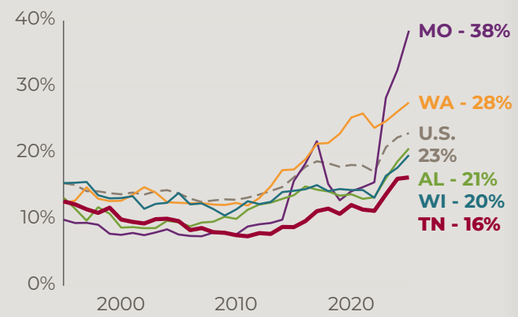
Latest year for each measure, given after its name. Dollars are 2024 dollars (CPI-U). Data from NCES, IPEDS.

Figure 23 Int. share of grad students



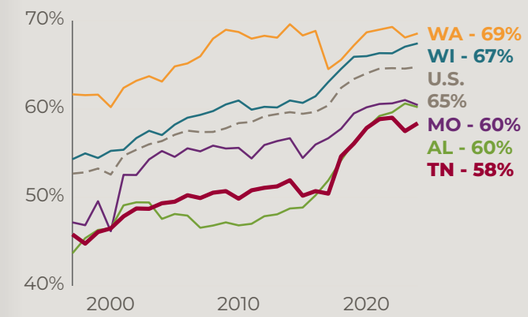
Data from NCES, IPEDS.

Figure 24 STEM share of master's



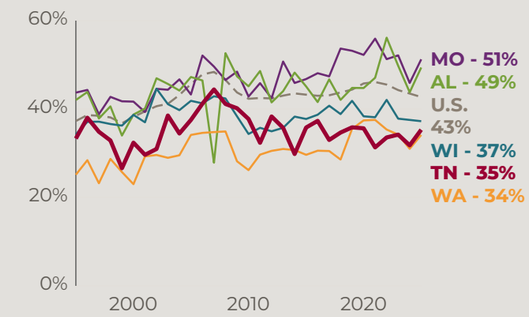
Data from NCES, IPEDS.

Figure 25 Six-year graduation rate



Data from NCES, IPEDS.

Figure 26 Int. share of STEM doctorates

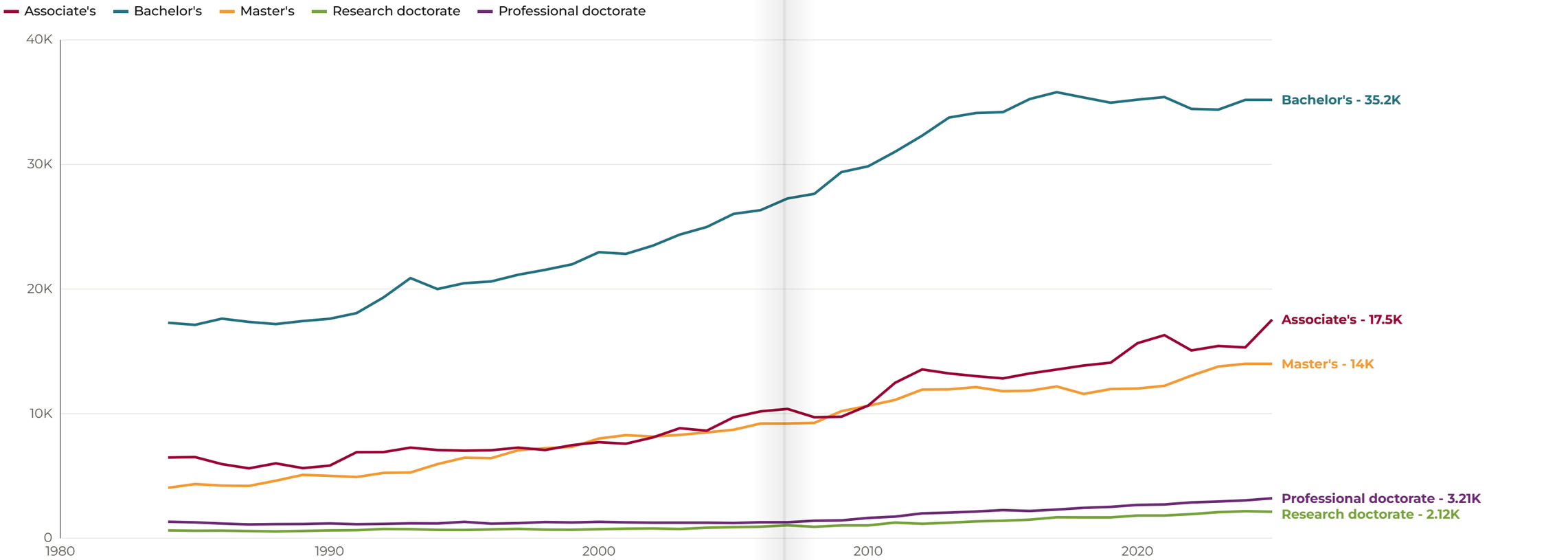


Data from NCES, IPEDS.

SECTION 12

Fields of Study

Figure 27 How Many Degrees Does Tennessee Award?

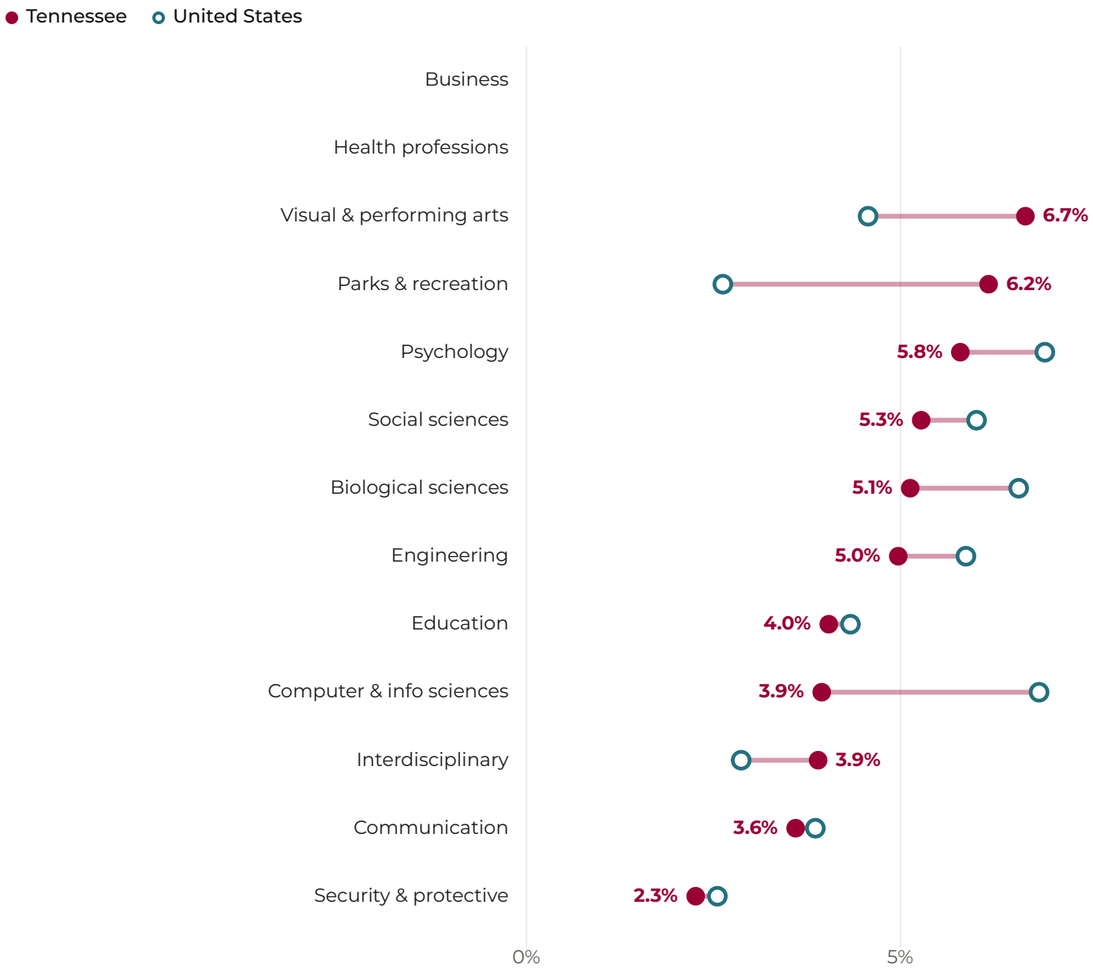


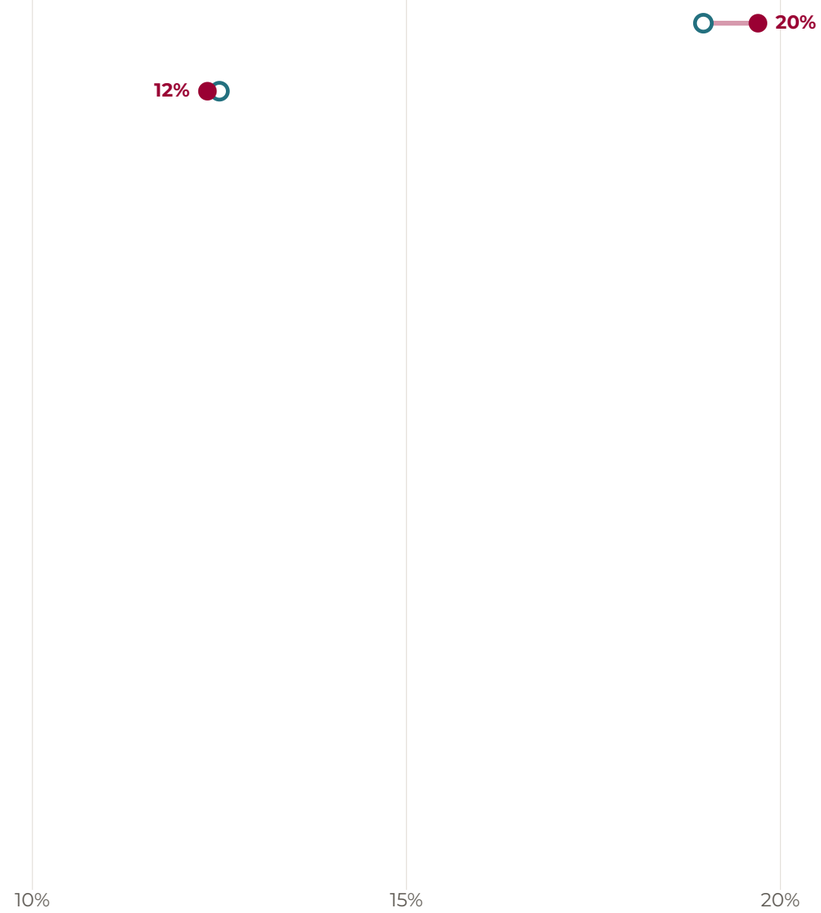
Degrees awarded by level, first majors. Data from NCES, IPEDS Completions.

In 2025, Tennessee's institutions awarded 17.5K associate's degrees, 35.2K bachelor's degrees, 14K master's degrees, 2.12K research doctorate degrees, 3.21K professional doctorate degrees.

Since 2015: associate's up 37%; bachelor's up 3%; master's up 19%; research doctorate up 51%; professional doctorate up 42%. The state awards 13.0 bachelor's degrees for every 100 undergraduates (U.S. 12.3).

Figure 28 What Do Tennessee's Bachelor's Graduates Study?





Share of bachelor's degrees by field, 2025. Data from NCES, IPEDS.

Tennessee's largest bachelor's fields are business (20%; U.S. 19%), health professions (12%; U.S. 13%), visual & performing arts (6.7%; U.S. 4.6%).

Relative to the nation, Tennessee's bachelor's degrees are most concentrated in communications tech (2.57× the U.S. share), theology (2.50× the U.S. share), parks & recreation (2.35× the U.S. share).

3.9%

Bachelor's in computer science, 2025

U.S. **6.9%** · **38th** of 51 · +1.8 pp since 2015

6.0%

Bachelor's in engineering & eng. technology, 2025

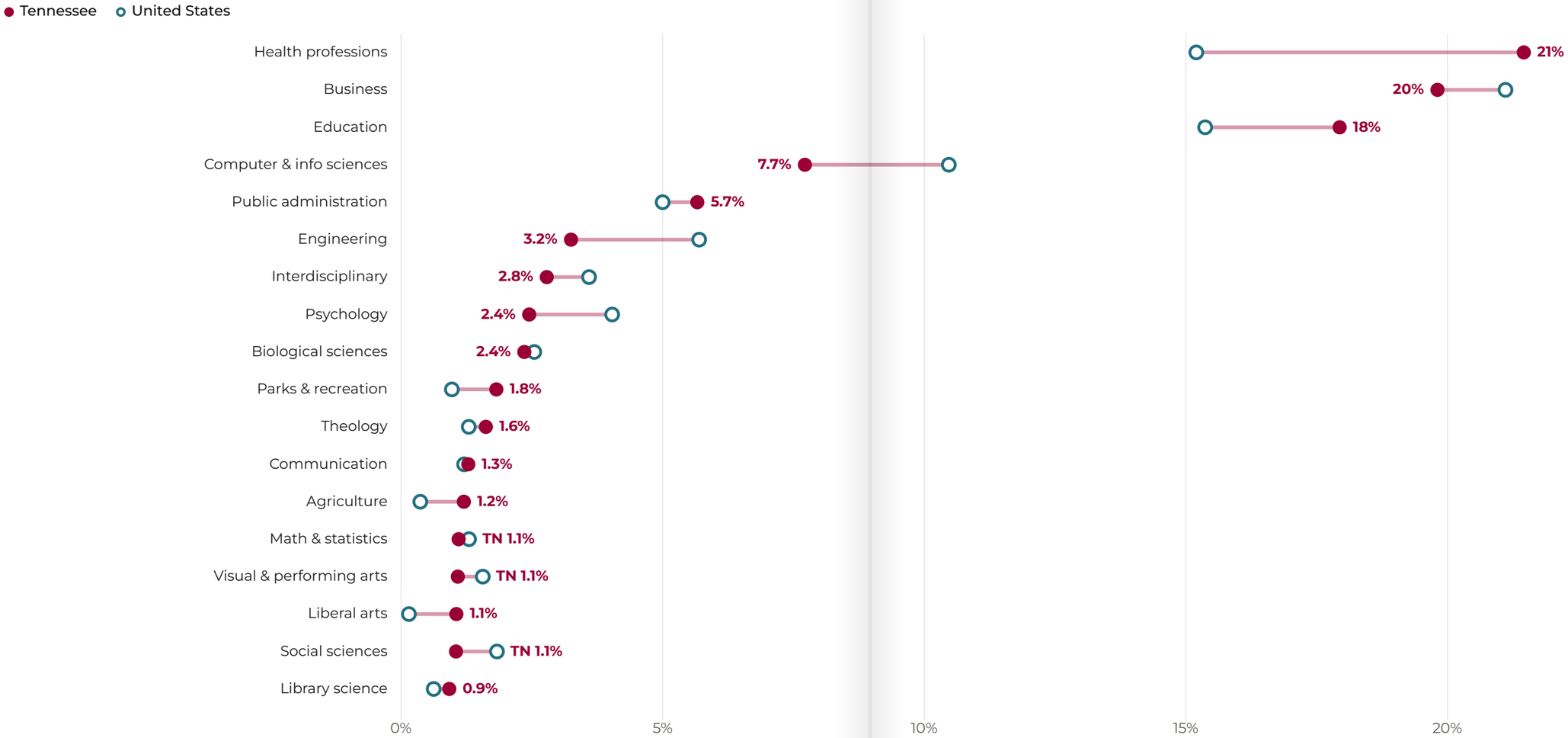
U.S. **6.8%** · **31st** of 51 · +1.1 pp since 2015

20%

Bachelor's in business, 2025

U.S. **19%** · **24th** of 51 · +1.7 pp since 2015

Figure 29 What Do Tennessee's Master's Graduates Study?



Share of master's degrees by field, 2025; largest fields. Data from NCES, IPEDS.

Tennessee's largest master's fields are health professions (21%; U.S. 15%), business (20%; U.S. 21%), education (18%; U.S. 15%).

International students earn 14% of all master's degrees in the state (U.S. 22%), and STEM fields account for 16% of them.

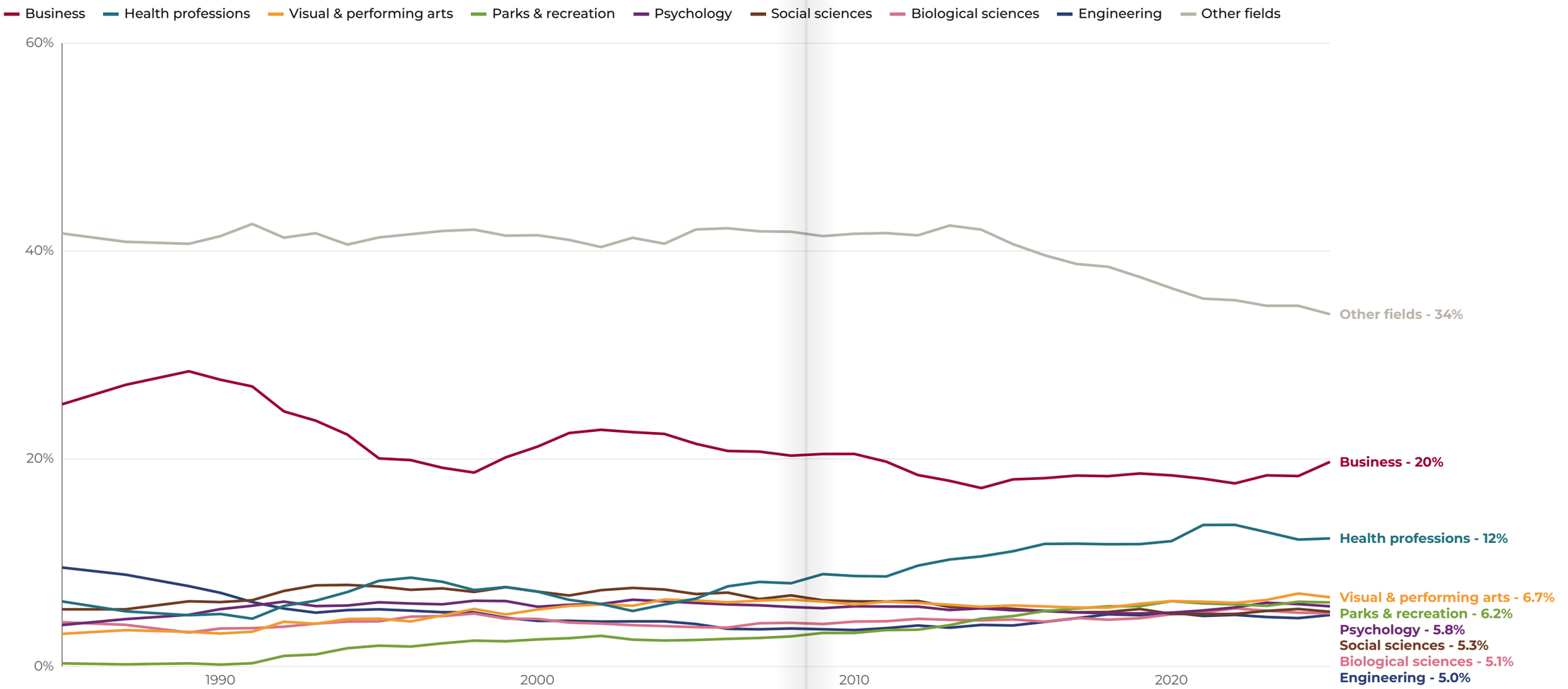
16%
STEM share of master's, 2025
U.S. **23%** · **38th** of 51 · +7.5 pp since 2015

14%
Int. share of all master's, 2025
U.S. **22%** · **28th** of 51 · +7.2 pp since 2015

76%
Int. share of CS master's, 2025
U.S. **65%** · **14th** of 47 · +42.3 pp since 2015

12

Figure 30 How Has Tennessee's Bachelor's Field Mix Changed?



Share of bachelor's degrees in the largest fields. Data from NCES, IPEDS Completions.

Since 2015, business has gained the most ground, 1.7 points of the state's bachelor's degrees, while social sciences lost the most (0.3 points).

The chart follows the share of bachelor's degrees in each of the state's largest fields; smaller fields are grouped as other fields.

SECTION 12 · FIELDS OF STUDY

Where Is Tennessee Specialized, and What Do Its Doctoral Graduates Study?

The location quotient divides a field's share of Tennessee's bachelor's degrees by its share of all U.S. bachelor's degrees in 2025. A quotient of 1.00 means the same share as the nation; 2.00 means twice the national share. The table lists the 10 fields with the highest quotients among fields with at least 50 degrees.

Highest location quotients. Communications tech (2.57, with 0.7% of the state's bachelor's degrees against 0.3% for the U.S.), theology (2.50, with 0.7% of the state's bachelor's degrees against 0.3% for the U.S.), and parks & recreation (2.35, with 6.2% of the state's bachelor's degrees against 2.6% for the U.S.) had the highest quotients.

Table 5 Where Is Tennessee Most Specialized?

Field	Location quotient	State share	U.S. share	Degrees
Communications tech	**2.57**	0.7%	0.3%	240
Theology	**2.50**	0.7%	0.3%	251
Parks & recreation	**2.35**	6.2%	2.6%	2.17K
Transportation	**1.98**	0.7%	0.4%	254
Agriculture	**1.83**	1.9%	1.0%	662
Visual & performing arts	**1.46**	6.7%	4.6%	2.35K
Interdisciplinary	**1.36**	3.9%	2.9%	1.37K
English	**1.17**	1.8%	1.5%	620
Engineering technology	**1.16**	1.0%	0.9%	364
Languages	**1.12**	0.6%	0.6%	227

Bachelor's degrees; location quotient = state share ÷ U.S. share; fields with 50+ degrees. Data from NCES, IPEDS.

18%
STEM share of bachelor's, 2025
U.S. **24%** · **44th** of 51

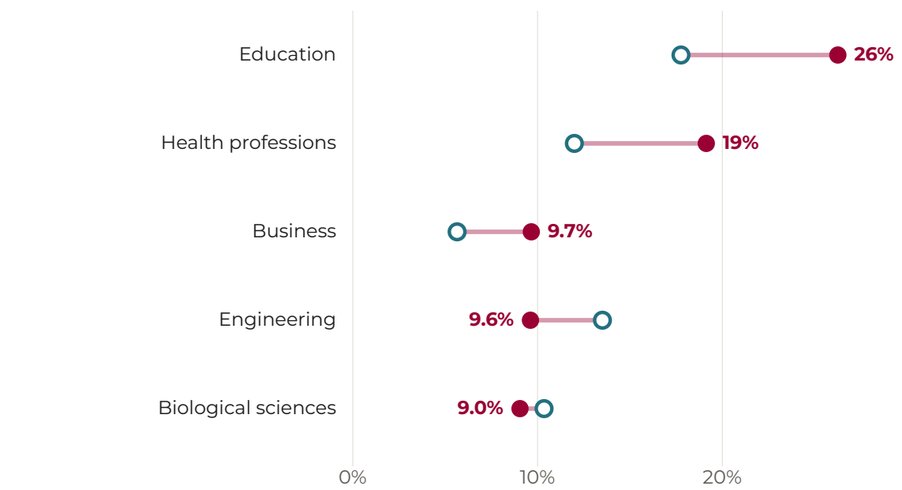
3.9%
Bachelor's in computer science, 2025
U.S. **6.9%** · **38th** of 51

6.0%
Bachelor's in engineering & eng. technology, 2025
U.S. **6.8%** · **31st** of 51

Each row is a field's share of the research doctorates awarded in Tennessee in 2025 (filled dot), against its share nationally (open dot), for the ten largest fields with at least 20 doctorates. Research doctorates exclude professional doctorates such as the M.D. and J.D.

Largest doctoral fields. The state's largest doctoral fields were education (26% of research doctorates, against 18% for the U.S.), health professions (19% of research doctorates, against 12% for the U.S.), and business (9.7% of research doctorates, against 5.6% for the U.S.).

Figure 31 What Do Tennessee's Doctoral Graduates Study?



Share of research doctorates by field, 2025; fields with 20+ doctorates. Data from NCES, IPEDS.

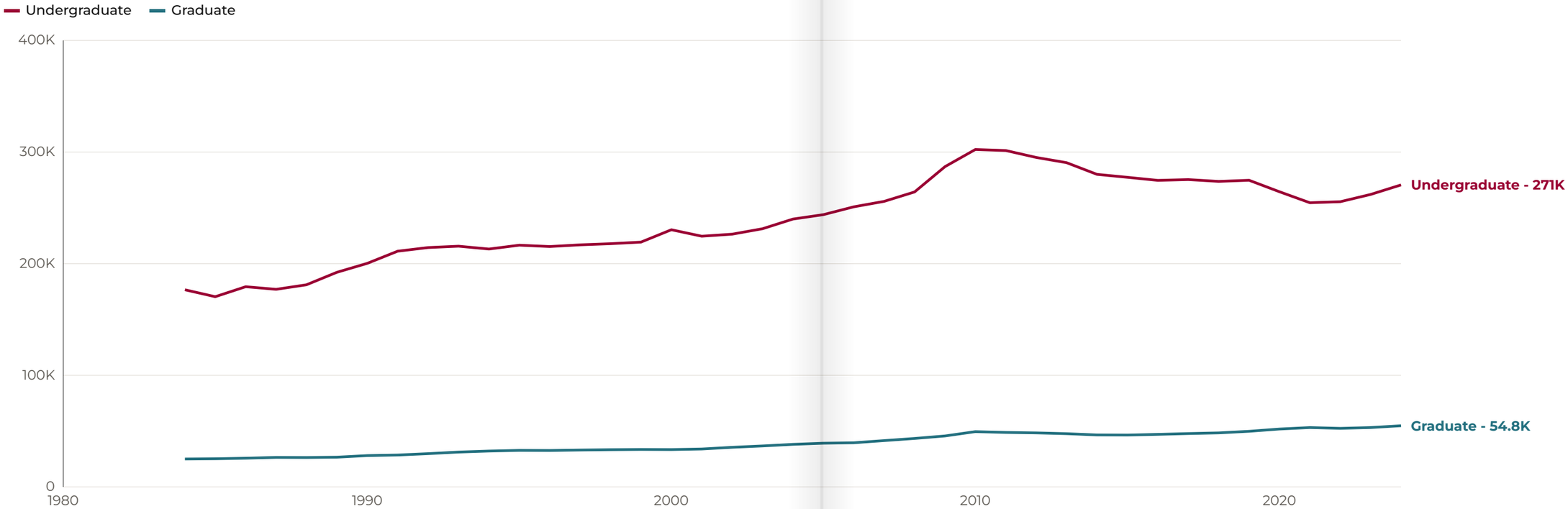
12

SECTION 13

Students and Money

Tennessee ranks 45th of 51 on the share of students enrolled part-time, at 29% in 2024 against 39% for the U.S.

Figure 32 How Has Enrollment Changed?



Fall headcount enrollment. Data from NCES, IPEDS Fall Enrollment.

In fall 2024, Tennessee enrolled 271K undergraduates and 54.8K graduate students, 325K in all (23rd of 51).

Undergraduate enrollment is down 2% since 2015 and graduate enrollment up 18% since 2015. Graduate students are 17% of all students (U.S. 17%).

325K

Students enrolled, 2024

U.S. **19.7M** · **23rd** of 51 · +0.5% since 2015

17%

Graduate share of students, 2024

U.S. **17%** · **19th** of 51 · +2.5 pp since 2015

29%

Students attending part-time, 2024

U.S. **39%** · **45th** of 51 · +0.7 pp since 2015

SECTION 13 · STUDENTS AND MONEY

Who Enrolls in Tennessee, and Where?

In fall 2024, White students were the largest group at Tennessee's degree-granting institutions, **60%** of enrollment against 45% nationally, down 6.1 points since 2015.

Black students were **17%** (U.S. 12%), down 1.1 points since 2015, and Hispanic students were **7.9%** (U.S. 21%), up 4.1 points since 2015.

Students of two or more races were **4.1%** (U.S. 4.2%), up 1.3 points since 2015, and Asian and Pacific Islander students were **3.5%** (U.S. 7.4%), up 1.1 points since 2015. "International" counts U.S. nonresidents on temporary visas, whatever their race.

Figure 33 Who Enrolls in Tennessee?

Tennessee · United States

		Change since 2015
White	60% (U.S. 45%)	−6.1 pts
Black	17% (U.S. 12%)	−1.1 pts
Hispanic	7.9% (U.S. 21%)	+4.1 pts
Two or more	4.1% (U.S. 4.2%)	+1.3 pts
Asian / Pacific Islander	3.5% (U.S. 7.4%)	+1.1 pts
International	3.4% (U.S. 5.3%)	+0.4 pts
American Indian	0.3% (U.S. 0.6%)	0.0 pts

Share of fall 2024 headcount enrollment by race and ethnicity; students of unknown race are left out of the chart. Data from NCES, IPEDS.

60%
White students
U.S. **45%** · −6.1 pp since 2015

17%
Black students
U.S. **12%** · −1.1 pp since 2015

44%
At public 4-year institutions
+2.0 pp since 2015

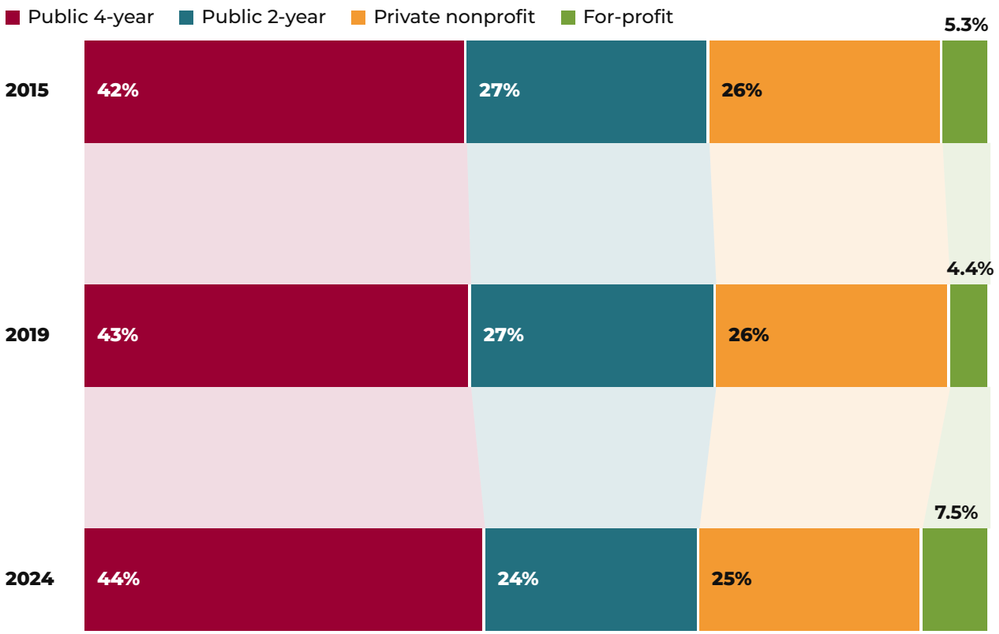
25%
At private nonprofit institutions
−1.1 pp since 2015

In fall 2024, public 4-year institutions enrolled **44%** of students, up 2.0 points from 42% in 2015. Private nonprofit institutions enrolled **25%** of students, down 1.1 points from 26% in 2015.

Public 2-year institutions enrolled **24%** of students, down 3.1 points from 27% in 2015, and for-profit institutions enrolled **7.5%** of students, up 2.2 points from 5.3% in 2015.

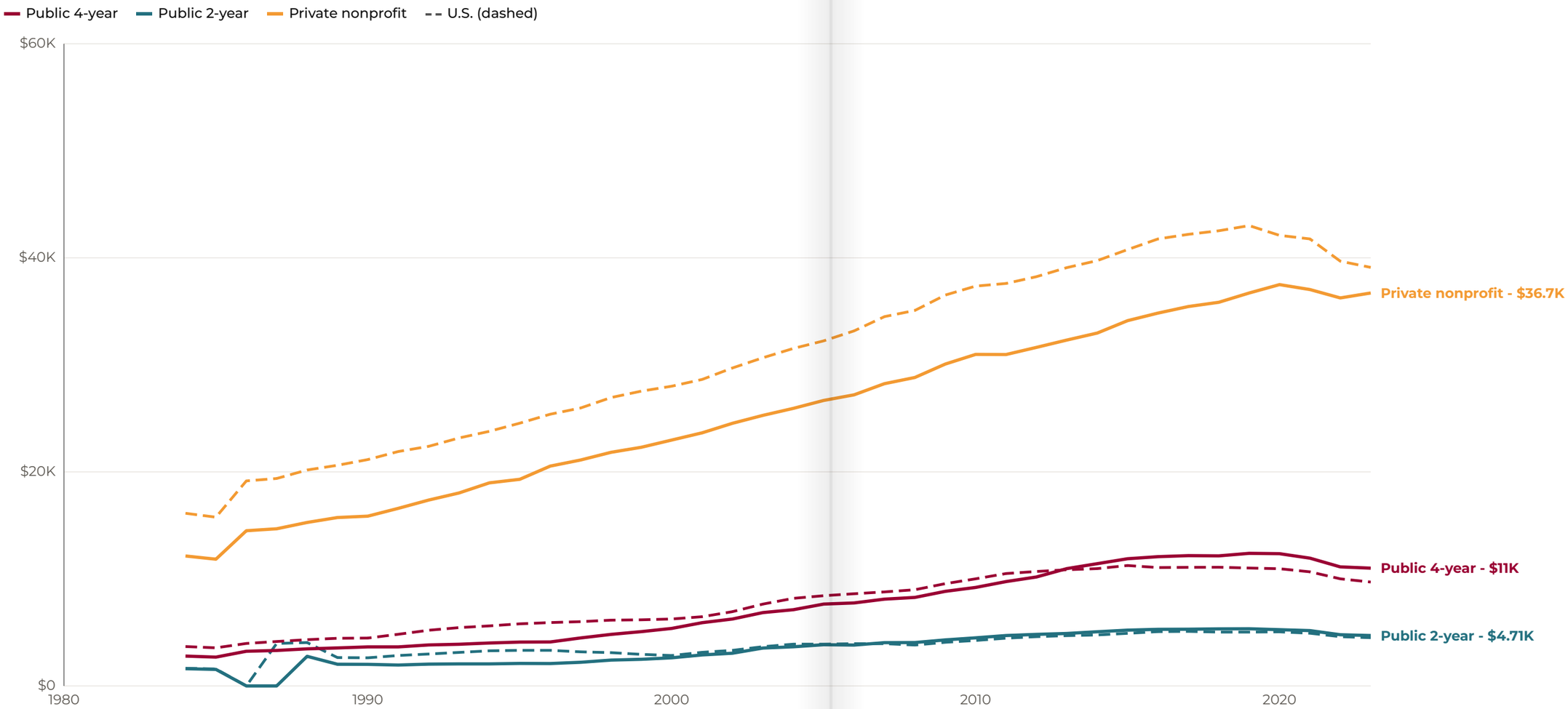
Public institutions together enrolled **68%** of students, against 73% nationally, 34th among the states.

Figure 34 Where Do Students Enroll?



Share of fall headcount enrollment by sector, 2015, 2019, 2024. Sectors as IPEDS classifies them each year. Data from NCES, IPEDS.

Figure 35 What Does In-State Tuition Cost?



Published in-state tuition and fees, 2024 dollars (CPI-U); state solid, U.S. dashed. Data from NCES, IPEDS.

In-state tuition and fees at Tennessee's public four-year institutions are $11K (2023, 2024 dollars), 13% above the U.S. ($9.71K); the state ranks 19th of 51.

State and local appropriations come to $12.1K per full-time-equivalent student at public institutions (13th of 51), and net tuition makes up 37% of net tuition plus state and local appropriations (U.S. 43%).

$11K

In-state tuition, public 4-year, 2023

U.S. **$9.71K** · **19th** of 51 · −7.3% since 2015

$12.1K

Appropriations per student, 2024

U.S. **$11.4K** · **13th** of 51 · +64% since 2015

37%

Tuition share of tuition plus appropriations, 2024

U.S. **43%** · **39th** of 51 · −13.0 pp since 2015

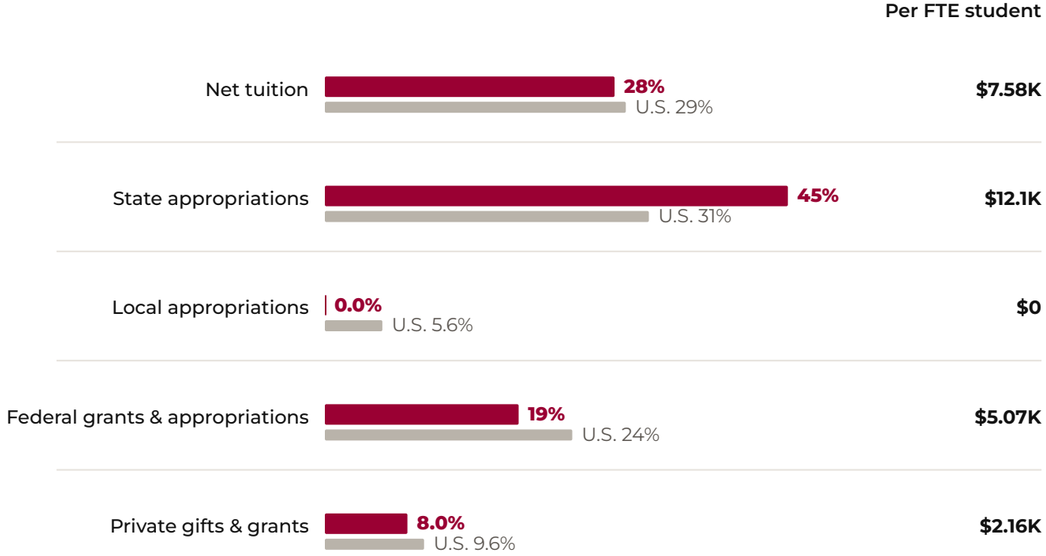
SECTION 13 · STUDENTS AND MONEY

How Are Tennessee's Public Institutions Funded, and What Do They Produce?

The bars give each source's share of the core revenue of Tennessee's public institutions, with the nation for comparison, and at right the dollars per full-time-equivalent (FTE) student it provides. Values are in 2024 dollars (CPI-U). Net tuition is tuition and fees after institutional discounts and allowances.

Net tuition per FTE student. The figure was $7.58K in FY2024, against $8.96K for the U.S., down 3.8% from $7.88K in FY2023 and down 6.4% since FY2015, when it was $8.1K.

Figure 36 How Are Public Institutions Funded?



Share of core revenue per FTE student by source, public institutions, FY2024; dollars per FTE at right, 2024 dollars (CPI-U). Shares are of all five sources; the tuition share elsewhere in this profile divides net tuition by net tuition plus state and local appropriations only. Data from NCES, IPEDS Finance.

$11K
In-state tuition, public 4-year, 2023
U.S. **$9.71K** · **19th** of 51

$12.1K
Appropriations per student, 2024
U.S. **$11.4K** · **13th** of 51

37%
Tuition share of tuition plus appropriations, 2024
U.S. **43%** · **39th** of 51

The table brings together five measures of what public higher education costs and what it produces in Tennessee: in-state tuition at public four-year institutions, state and local appropriations per full-time-equivalent student, tuition's share of public institutions' core revenue, the six-year bachelor's graduation rate, and the average full-time faculty salary.

In-state tuition, public 4-year. The figure was $11K in 2023, against $9.71K for the U.S., 19th among the states, down 1.0% from $11.1K in 2022 and down 7.3% since 2015, when it was $11.9K.

Table 6 Money and Results

Measure	Year	Tennessee	U.S.	Rank	Change since 2015
In-state tuition, public 4-year	2023	**$11K**	$9.71K	19th of 51	−7.3%
Appropriations per student	2024	**$12.1K**	$11.4K	13th of 51	+64%
Tuition share of tuition plus appropriations	2024	**37%**	43%	39th of 51	−13.0 pp
Six-year graduation rate	2024	**58%**	65%	36th of 51	+8.2 pp
Average faculty salary	2024	**$92.8K**	$106K	33rd of 51	−5.5%

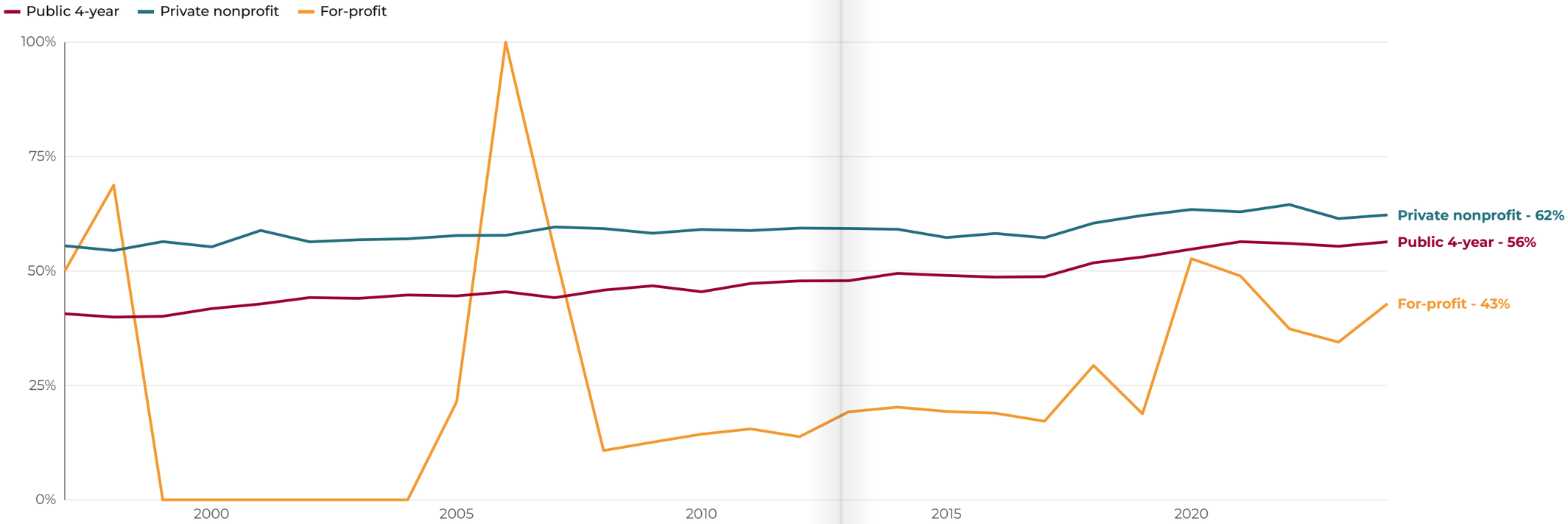
Rank among the 50 states and DC (1 = highest). Dollars in 2024 dollars (CPI-U). Data from NCES, IPEDS.

SECTION 14

Student Outcomes

Tennessee ranks 39th of 50 on the share of completion within 150% of normal time, 2-year institutions, at 34% in 2024 against 41% for the U.S.

Figure 37 How Do Graduation Rates Differ by Sector?



Six-year bachelor's graduation rate by sector of institution. Data from NCES, IPEDS Graduation Rates.

58% of students who started a bachelor's degree at a four-year institution in Tennessee graduated within six years (2024), 6.4 points below the U.S. (65%); the state ranks 36th of 51.

By sector: public 4-year 56%, private nonprofit 62%, for-profit 43%. At two-year institutions, 34% complete within 150% of normal time (U.S. 41%).

58%
Six-year graduation rate, 2024
U.S. **65%** · **36th** of 51 · +8.2 pp since 2015

34%
Two-year completion rate, 2024
U.S. **41%** · **39th** of 50 · +5.9 pp since 2015

13.0
Bachelor's per 100 undergraduates, 2025
U.S. **12.3** · **21st** of 51 · +0.8 since 2015

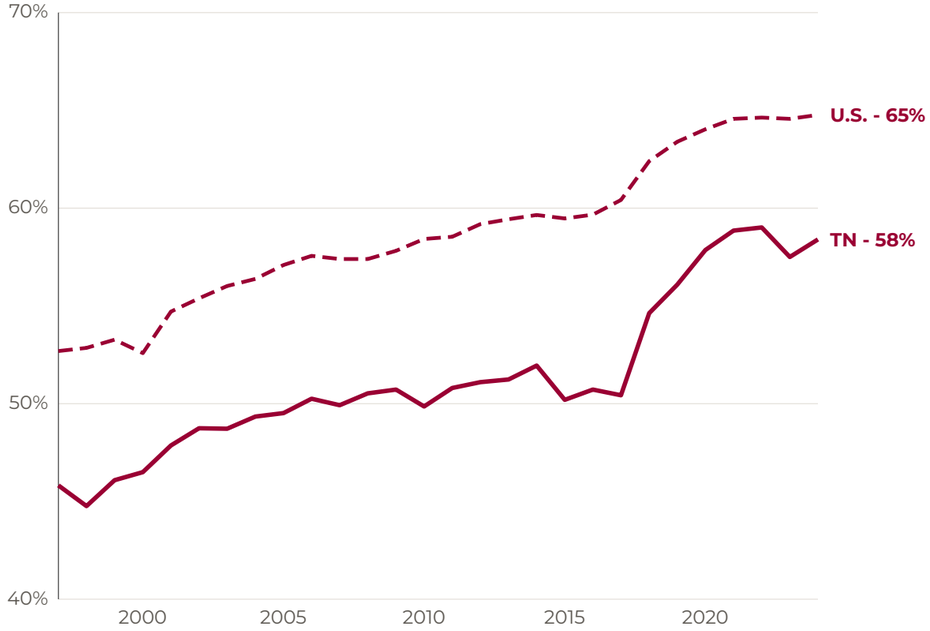
SECTION 14 · STUDENT OUTCOMES

How Many of Tennessee's Students Graduate?

The line follows the share of first-time, full-time bachelor's-degree students at Tennessee's four-year institutions who graduated from the institution where they started within six years (150% of normal time). Each year is the cohort that entered six years earlier. The rate leaves out students who start part-time (29% of the state's students attend part-time, against 39% nationally) and students who transfer and finish elsewhere. The state is solid and the United States dashed.

Six-year graduation rate. The rate was 58% in 2024, against 65% for the U.S., up 0.9 points from 58% in 2023 and up 8.2 points since 2015, when it was 50%.

Figure 38 Six-Year Bachelor's Graduation Rate



Four-year institutions; state solid, U.S. dashed. Data from NCES, IPEDS Graduation Rates.

58%
Six-year graduation rate, 2024
U.S. **65%** · **36th** of 51

34%
Two-year completion rate, 2024
U.S. **41%** · **39th** of 50

13.0
Bachelor's per 100 undergraduates, 2025
U.S. **12.3** · **21st** of 51

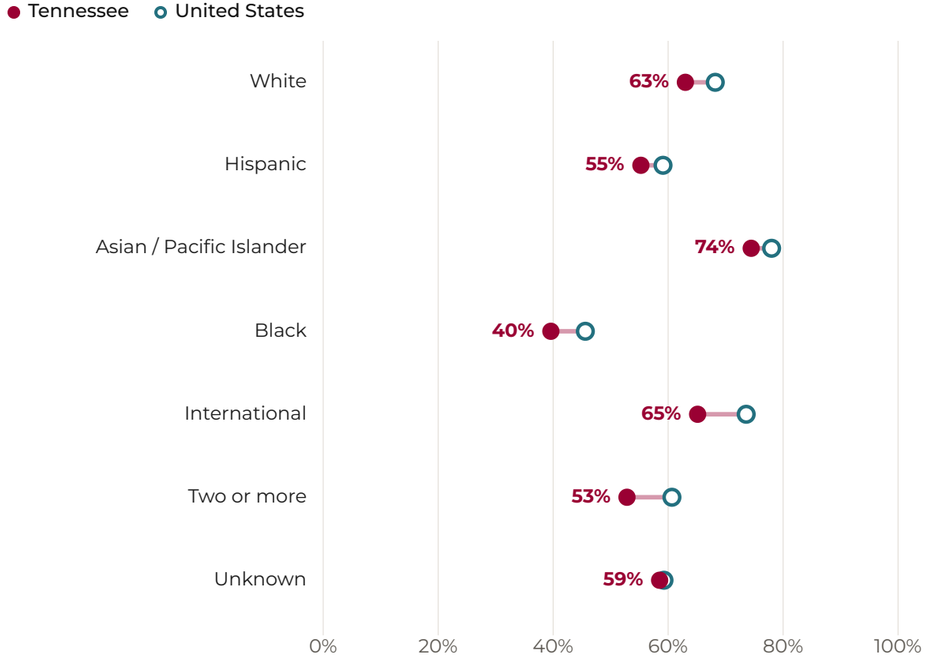
Each row is the six-year bachelor's graduation rate for one racial or ethnic group of students at Tennessee's four-year institutions (filled dot), against the national rate for the same group (open dot). Groups with fewer than 100 students in the cohort are left out.

White. The six-year rate was 63% in 2024, against 68% for the U.S.

Hispanic. The six-year rate was 55% in 2024, against 59% for the U.S.

Asian / Pacific Islander. The six-year rate was 74% in 2024, against 78% for the U.S.

Figure 39 How Do Graduation Rates Differ by Race and Ethnicity?



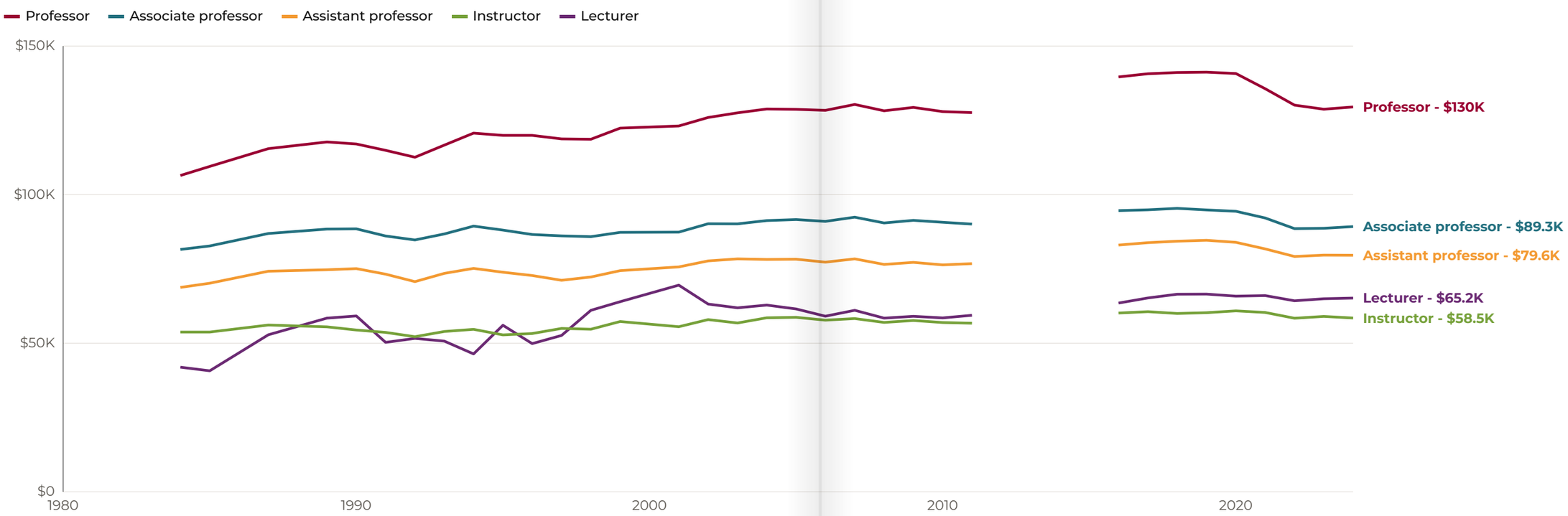
Six-year rate, 2024; groups with 100+ students. Data from NCES, IPEDS.

SECTION 15

Faculty

Tennessee ranks 33rd of 51 on the average full-time faculty salary, at $92.8K in 2024 against $106K for the U.S.

Figure 40 What Do Tennessee's Faculty Earn, by Rank?



Average salary of full-time instructional faculty on 9/10-month contracts, by academic rank, 2024 dollars (CPI-U). Data from NCES, IPEDS Human Resources.

Full-time instructional faculty on 9/10-month contracts at Tennessee's institutions earned an average of $92.8K in 2024 (2024 dollars), 12% below the U.S. ($106K); the state ranks 33rd of 51. By rank (2024): professors $130K, associate professors $89.3K, assistant professors $79.6K, instructors $58.5K, lecturers $65.2K.

Tennessee's institutions had 15.6K full-time instructional staff in 2024, down 5% since 2015. Average salary across all ranks is down 5% since 2016.

$92.8K

Average faculty salary, 2024

U.S. **$106K** · **33rd** of 51 · −5.5% since 2016

SECTION 15 · FACULTY

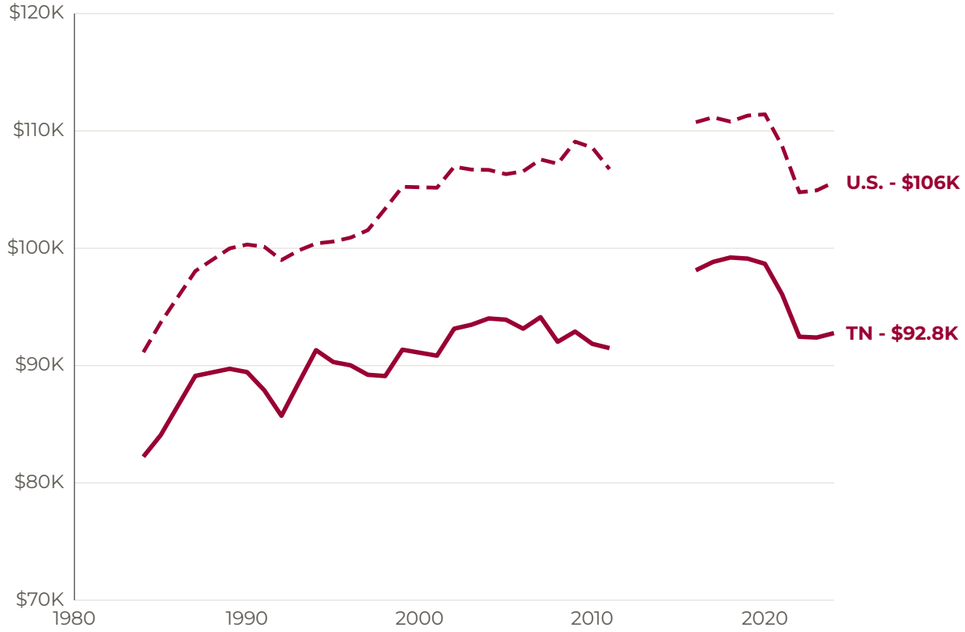
What Do Tennessee's Faculty Earn, and How Many Hold Tenure?

The line follows the average salary of full-time instructional faculty on 9- or 10-month contracts at Tennessee's degree-granting institutions, all ranks combined, in 2024 dollars (CPI-U). The state is solid and the United States dashed.

Average salary. The figure was $92.8K in 2024, against $106K for the U.S., 33rd among the states, up 0.4% from $92.4K in 2023 and down 5.5% since 2016, when it was $98.1K.

Full-time instructional staff. The number was 15.6K in 2024, up 3.0% from 15.1K in 2023 and down 5.2% since 2015, when it was 16.4K.

Figure 41 Average Faculty Salary



Full-time instructional faculty, 9/10-month, 2024 dollars. Data from NCES, IPEDS.

$92.8K
Average faculty salary, 2024
U.S. **$106K** · **33rd** of 51

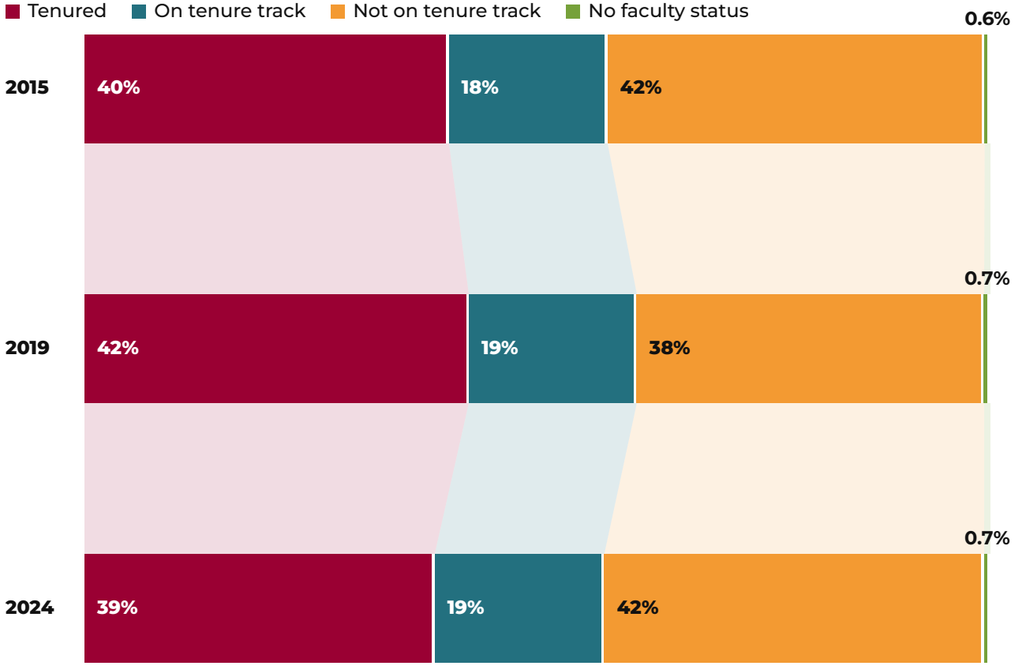
15.6K
Full-time instructional staff, 2024

39%
Tenured, 2024

The bars divide Tennessee's full-time instructional staff by tenure status in 2015, 2019 and 2024: tenured, on the tenure track, not on the tenure track (for example, lecturers on fixed-term contracts), and staff at institutions with no tenure system.

Tenured, share of full-time instructional staff. The share was 39% in 2024, down 0.7 points from 39% in 2023 and down 1.6 points since 2015, when it was 40%.

Figure 42 Tenure Status



Full-time instructional staff by tenure status, 2015, 2019, 2024. Data from NCES, IPEDS.

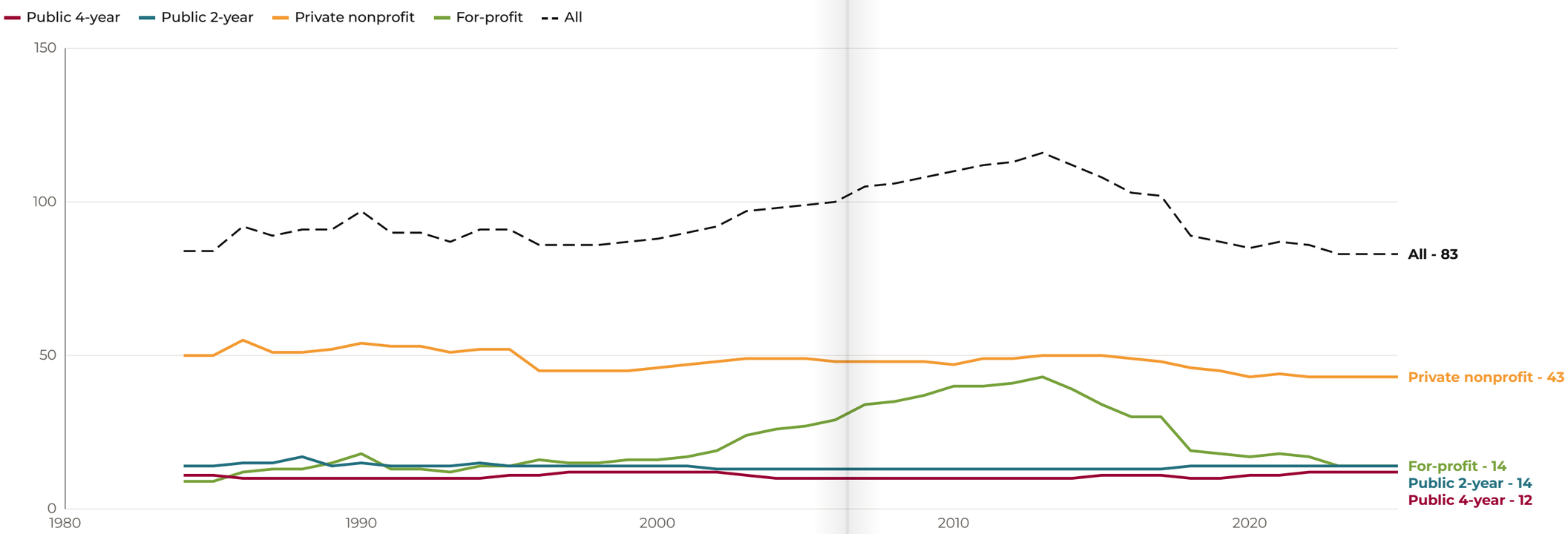
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SECTION 16

Institutions

Tennessee ranks 9th of 51 on the share of enrollment at for-profit institutions, at 7.5% in 2024 against 5.5% for the U.S.

Figure 43 How Many Institutions Does Tennessee Have?



Degree-granting institutions by sector. Data from NCES, IPEDS.

Tennessee has 83 degree-granting institutions:12 public 4-year, 14 public 2-year, 43 private nonprofit, 14 for-profit (2025).

The number of institutions is down 23% since 2015. 68% of students attend public institutions and 7.5% attend for-profit ones.

68%

Students at public institutions, 2024

U.S. **73%** · **34th** of 51 · −1.1 pp since 2015

7.5%

Students at for-profit institutions, 2024

U.S. **5.5%** · **9th** of 51 · +2.2 pp since 2015

20%

Students fully online, 2024

U.S. **27%** · **39th** of 51 · +11.0 pp since 2015

SECTION 16 · INSTITUTIONS

Which Institutions Lead in Tennessee?

The table ranks institutions in Tennessee by the STEM master's degrees and research doctorates they awarded to international students in 2025, the two counted together. The share columns give international students' share of each institution's STEM degrees at that level.

Largest. University of Memphis (345 international STEM master's degrees and 36 doctorates), Christian Brothers University (251 international STEM master's degrees and – doctorates), and The University of Tennessee-Knoxville (98 international STEM master's degrees and 84 doctorates) awarded the most.

Table 7 Which Institutions Train the Most International STEM Graduates?

Institution	STEM total	STEM master's	Int. share	STEM doctorates	Int. share
University of Memphis Memphis · Public 4-year	**381**	345	73%	36	63%
Christian Brothers University Memphis · Private nonprofit	**251**	251	95%	–	–
The University of Tennessee-Knoxville Knoxville · Public 4-year	**182**	98	20%	84	38%
Cumberland University Lebanon · Private nonprofit	**159**	159	100%	–	–
Vanderbilt University Nashville · Private nonprofit	**139**	91	28%	48	23%
Middle Tennessee State University Murfreesboro · Public 4-year	**58**	55	39%	3	50%
East Tennessee State University Johnson City · Public 4-year	**55**	54	62%	1	33%
Tennessee Technological University Cookeville · Public 4-year	**36**	23	33%	13	52%

Ranked by the total (shaded) of international STEM master's degrees and research doctorates. Degrees awarded in 2025. Data from NCES, IPEDS.

83
Degree-granting institutions, 2025

68%
Students at public institutions, 2024
U.S. **73%** · **34th** of 51

7.5%
Students at for-profit institutions, 2024
U.S. **5.5%** · **9th** of 51

20%
Students fully online, 2024
U.S. **27%** · **39th** of 51

The table lists Tennessee's largest degree-granting institutions by fall 2024 headcount enrollment, with the international share of graduate students, STEM bachelor's degrees awarded in 2025, the six-year graduation rate and the admission rate (a dash where the institution admits all applicants or does not report one).

Largest. The three largest were The University of Tennessee-Knoxville (38.7K students), Middle Tennessee State University (20.5K students), and University of Memphis (20.3K students).

Degree-granting institutions. The state had 83 in 2025, and 80 of them reported the enrollment and degree data in these tables.

Table 8 What Are Tennessee's Largest Institutions?

Institution	Enrollment	Int. share, grad	STEM bachelor's	Six-year grad rate	Admit rate
The University of Tennessee-Knoxville	**38.7K**	14%	1.55K	74%	42%
Middle Tennessee State University	**20.5K**	9.4%	500	54%	69%
University of Memphis	**20.3K**	27%	453	51%	72%
East Tennessee State University	**13.7K**	9.0%	267	53%	86%
Vanderbilt University	**13.6K**	16%	585	94%	5.9%
The University of Tennessee-Chattanooga	**11.8K**	4.4%	512	50%	81%
South College	**11.6K**	2.6%	15	–	–
Tennessee Technological University	**10.5K**	11%	750	58%	76%
Austin Peay State University	**10.4K**	5.9%	186	39%	96%
Pellissippi State Community College	**9.4K**	–	–	–	–

Fall 2024 enrollment; degrees 2025. Data from NCES, IPEDS.

NOTES

About These Data

International students

U.S. nonresidents on temporary visas, as IPEDS defines them. IPEDS does not record country of citizenship. Permanent residents count with U.S. citizens.

STEM

CIP families 03, 04, 11, 14, 15, 26, 27 and 40. Doctorates are research and scholarship doctorates; professional doctorates appear only in the degree-count figure. Degrees are first majors only.

Universe

Degree-granting institutions located in the state; Title IV participants from 1996. Geography is the institution's location, not the student's home. Enrollment is fall headcount.

Migration

First-time degree-seeking undergraduates by home state, reported in even years before 2001 and every year since; odd years with incomplete reporting are omitted. Net migration is students arriving from other states minus residents leaving, per 100 resident first-time students.

Money

Tuition, appropriations, revenue and faculty salaries are in 2024 dollars using the CPI-U. Research funding (HERD, Federal Funds, USAspending), wages and the NAFSA economic contribution are nominal dollars, and are labeled so. Appropriations and revenue are per full-time-equivalent student at public institutions; the tuition share divides net tuition by net tuition plus state and local appropriations.

Race and ethnicity

IPEDS did not collect race and ethnicity in every year before 2010, and categories changed in 2008–2010; “Two or more” exists only from then.

Countries of citizenship

From DHS SEVIS by the Numbers: active F-1 and M-1 student records in the month named, at every level from primary school to doctorate, by the state of the school. IPEDS records only whether a student is a U.S. nonresident, not where they come from. SEVIS counts are monthly snapshots and are not directly comparable with IPEDS fall enrollment or degree counts. Year-to-year comparisons use one fall snapshot per year (the month closest to November).

Peers

Comparison states are the four closest in total fall enrollment, measured proportionally: a state 1.5 times as large counts as near as one two-thirds the size.

Sources

IPEDS (National Center for Education Statistics) is the backbone: Institutional Characteristics, Fall Enrollment, Completions, Graduation Rates, Finance, Human Resources and Admissions, 1980–2025, harmonized into a state panel. The profile also draws on NAEP, NSF's Survey of Graduate Students and Postdoctorates, Survey of Earned Doctorates, HERD and Federal Funds surveys, USAspending.gov, DHS SEVIS by the Numbers and ICE SEVIS releases, the Department of Labor's Office of Foreign Labor Certification and BLS wage data, the USCIS H-1B Employer Data Hub, the Census Bureau's American Community Survey and Post-Secondary Employment Outcomes, USPTO PatentsView, and other federal sources; every figure names its source, and the Sources page lists them in full. Generated November 2026.

NOTES

How the Numbers Are Counted

Ranks

Ranks are among the 50 states and the District of Columbia (1 = highest value, whether or not a high value is good). Where fewer than 51 report, the count is given ("23rd of 33").

Sectors

Sectors are as IPEDS classifies institutions each year. IPEDS moves a whole institution to "public, 4-year or above" once it awards any bachelor's degree, so community colleges that began offering applied bachelor's degrees carry all of their students into the public 4-year sector. Sector series (enrollment shares, public 4-year tuition, graduation rates by sector) reflect these moves.

Research doctorates

Two counts appear. IPEDS counts degrees institutions report as "doctor's degree, research/scholarship", which includes some practice-oriented degrees such as many Ed.D.s; the NSF Survey of Earned Doctorates counts research doctorate recipients and is smaller. Each figure names which it uses. "STEM master's per STEM research doctorate" divides IPEDS STEM master's degrees by IPEDS STEM research doctorates.

Engineering

"Engineering" alone is CIP 14. Where engineering technology (CIP 15) is added, the label says "engineering & eng. technology".

Graduation rates

IPEDS graduation rates follow first-time, full-time students and count only those who finish at the institution where they started, so they leave out part-time starters and students who transfer and finish elsewhere.

International students in SEVIS

SEVIS counts active F-1 and M-1 records, which include graduates on Optional Practical Training (up to 36 months for STEM graduates, 12 for others), so STEM shares run high. STEM follows the DHS STEM Designated Degree Program List, which is broader than the eight CIP families above, and DHS draws its STEM pages on a different basis from its all-student pages, so a country's STEM count can exceed its all-level count.

Visas and green cards

DOL labor condition applications (H-1B positions) are counted by worksite and include renewals and job changes; USCIS approvals are counted by the employer's address and split into new and continuing. PERM certifications are the employer's step toward a green card.

Patents

Patents are counted by the owner's (assignee's) location, not where inventors live; a company headquartered in another state takes its patents there.

Years

Each measure uses its latest year, so years differ across a page; every figure, table and statement gives its year, and lines that stop early are labeled with their last year.

Tennessee – By the Numbers

Measure	2015	Latest	Change since 2015	U.S., latest	U.S. change since 2015	Rank	Source
K-12 PREPARATION							
Grade 8 mathematics, average score	278	**276**[2024]	−2.2 ▼	272	−9.0 ▼	#19	[5]
Grade 8 mathematics: at or above Proficient	29%	**31%**[2024]	+1.3 pp ▲	27%	−5.3 pp ▼	#18	[5]
Grade 4 mathematics, average score	241	**240**[2024]	−1.1 ▼	237	−2.5 ▼	#12	[5]
Grade 4 mathematics: at or above Proficient	40%	**42%**[2024]	+1.5 pp ▲	39%	0.0 pp	#16	[5]
Grade 8 reading, average score	265	**259**[2024]	−5.8 ▼	257	−7.3 ▼	#20	[5]
Grade 8 reading: at or above Proficient	33%	**31%**[2024]	−1.8 pp ▼	29%	−4.0 pp ▼	#16	[5]
Grade 4 reading, average score	219	**215**[2024]	−3.6 ▼	214	−7.1 ▼	#23	[5]
Grade 8 science, average score, 2009 framework	–	**156**[2015]	–	153	–	#21	[5]
Current spending per public-school pupil	$11.5K	**$12.4K**[2021]	+8.3% ▲	$16.8K	+12% ▲	#44	[3]
Public high school 4-year graduation rate, ACGR	88%	**90%**[2022]	+2.0 pp ▲	87%	+4.0 pp ▲	#2	[3]
Public high school graduates	62K	**64.4K**[2024]	+3.8% ▲	3.49M	+8.8% ▲	#17	[3]
Average public-school teacher salary	$62.8K	**$58.9K**[2022]	−6.2% ▼	$72.9K	−3.0% ▼	#43	[3]
Pupils per teacher, public schools	15.1	**15.3**[2022]	+0.2 ▲	15.4	−0.6 ▼	#19	[3]
Public elementary and secondary enrollment	1M	**1M**[2024]	+0.2% ▲	49.4M	−2.1% ▼	#16	[3]
Public-school students eligible for free or reduced-price lunch	56%	**30%**[2023]	−25.8 pp ▼	53%	+1.5 pp ▲	#47	[3]
English learners as a share of public-school students	3.6%	**5.8%**[2022]	+2.2 pp ▲	11%	+1.0 pp ▲	#34	[3]
Charter-school share of public-school enrollment	2.2%	**4.4%**[2023]	+2.2 pp ▲	7.6%	+2.2 pp ▲	#29	[3]
High schools offering calculus	55%[2016]	**42%**[2024]	−13.5 pp ▼	51%	−5.8 pp ▼	#36	[14]
High schools offering physics	63%[2016]	**56%**[2024]	−7.3 pp ▼	64%	−2.4 pp ▼	#34	[14]
High schools offering chemistry	93%[2016]	**91%**[2024]	−1.4 pp ▼	81%	+0.7 pp ▲	#11	[14]
High schools offering Algebra II	93%[2016]	**93%**[2024]	−0.3 pp ▼	87%	+1.3 pp ▲	#16	[14]
High schools offering computer science	47%[2021]	**48%**[2024]	+0.5 pp ▲	55%	+2.0 pp ▲	#38	[14]
High schools offering any AP course	52%[2016]	**67%**[2024]	+14.2 pp ▲	56%	0.0 pp	#20	[14]
High schools offering AP computer science	20%[2021]	**22%**[2024]	+1.5 pp ▲	25%	+2.6 pp ▲	#29	[14]

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TENNESSEE – BY THE NUMBERS (CONTINUED)

Measure	2015	Latest	Change since 2015	U.S., latest	U.S. change since 2015	Rank	Source
K-12 PREPARATION (CONTINUED)							
High schools offering dual enrollment	77%[2016]	**82%[2024]**	+5.5 pp ▲	71%	+11.1 pp ▲	#19	[14]
AP course enrollments per 100 high-school students	11.1[2016]	**21.0[2024]**	+10.0 ▲	18.4	+1.0 ▲	#12	[14]
Calculus enrollments per 100 high-school students	2.2[2016]	**1.6[2024]**	−0.6 ▼	3.3	−1.0 ▼	#43	[14]
Physics enrollments per 100 high-school students	4.6[2016]	**5.2[2024]**	+0.6 ▲	9.4	−0.4 ▼	#39	[14]
SAT or ACT takers per 100 high-school students	26.8[2016]	**36.9[2024]**	+10.1 ▲	18.1	−2.5 ▼	#2	[14]
Students in gifted and talented programs per 100 students	1.6[2016]	**1.7[2024]**	+0.1 ▲	7.0	+0.4 ▲	#43	[14]
ENROLLMENT AND INSTITUTIONS							
Pell Grant share of undergraduates	42%	**38%[2025]**	−4.1 pp ▼	36%	−0.8 pp ▼	#13	[15]
Fall enrollment	324K	**325K[2024]**	+0.5% ▲	19.7M	−1.7% ▼	#23	[4]
Share of enrollment at public institutions	69%	**68%[2024]**	−1.1 pp ▼	73%	0.0 pp	#34	[4]
Share of enrollment at for-profit institutions	5.3%	**7.5%[2024]**	+2.2 pp ▲	5.5%	−1.2 pp ▼	#9	[4]
Share of students enrolled part-time	28%	**29%[2024]**	+0.7 pp ▲	39%	+0.7 pp ▲	#45	[4]
Share of students who are graduate students	14%	**17%[2024]**	+2.5 pp ▲	17%	+2.0 pp ▲	#19	[4]
Share of students enrolled exclusively online	9.1%	**20%[2024]**	+11.0 pp ▲	27%	+12.1 pp ▲	#39	[4]
DEGREES AND FIELDS OF STUDY							
Research doctorates awarded	900	**1.01K[2025]**	+13% ▲	59K	+7.3% ▲	#20	[7]
Science & engineering research doctorates, excluding health	602	**732[2025]**	+22% ▲	44.4K	+14% ▲	#20	[7]
Share of U.S. research doctorates	1.6%	**1.7%[2025]**	+0.1 pp ▲	–	–	#20	[7]
Engineering research doctorates	152	**174[2025]**	+14% ▲	10.9K	+9.9% ▲	#19	[7]
Mathematics & computer science research doctorates	35	**67[2025]**	–	5.07K	+33% ▲	#20	[7]
STEM master's degrees per research doctorate	2.4	**4.1[2025]**	+1.7 ▲	6.4	+2.1 ▲	#38	[4]
STEM share of bachelor's	15%	**18%[2025]**	+3.4 pp ▲	24%	+5.3 pp ▲	#44	[4]
Share of bachelor's in computer & information sciences	2.2%	**3.9%[2025]**	+1.8 pp ▲	6.9%	+3.7 pp ▲	#38	[4]
Share of bachelor's in engineering & eng. technology	4.9%	**6.0%[2025]**	+1.1 pp ▲	6.8%	+0.7 pp ▲	#31	[4]
Share of bachelor's in mathematics & statistics	0.9%	**0.7%[2025]**	−0.2 pp ▼	1.2%	0.0 pp	#35	[4]

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TENNESSEE – BY THE NUMBERS (CONTINUED)

Measure	2015	Latest	Change since 2015	U.S., latest	U.S. change since 2015	Rank	Source
DEGREES AND FIELDS OF STUDY (CONTINUED)							
Share of bachelor's in biological & biomedical sciences	4.5%	**5.1%**[2025]	+0.6 pp ▲	6.6%	+0.8 pp ▲	#45	[4]
Share of bachelor's in physical sciences	1.7%	**1.3%**[2025]	−0.4 pp ▼	1.3%	−0.3 pp ▼	#24	[4]
Share of bachelor's in health professions	11%	**12%**[2025]	+1.2 pp ▲	12%	+1.1 pp ▲	#24	[4]
Share of bachelor's in business	18%	**20%**[2025]	+1.7 pp ▲	19%	−0.1 pp ▼	#24	[4]
STEM share of master's	8.9%	**16%**[2025]	+7.5 pp ▲	23%	+6.7 pp ▲	#38	[4]
Share of master's in computer & information sciences	1.2%	**7.7%**[2025]	+6.5 pp ▲	10%	+6.3 pp ▲	#26	[4]
Share of master's in engineering & eng. technology	3.1%	**3.9%**[2025]	+0.7 pp ▲	6.7%	−0.2 pp ▼	#38	[4]
Share of master's in mathematics & statistics	0.8%	**1.1%**[2025]	+0.3 pp ▲	1.3%	+0.3 pp ▲	#25	[4]
Share of master's in biological & biomedical sciences	2.3%	**2.4%**[2025]	+0.1 pp ▲	2.5%	+0.6 pp ▲	#28	[4]
Share of master's in physical sciences	0.8%	**0.8%**[2025]	−0.1 pp ▼	0.8%	−0.1 pp ▼	#27	[4]
Share of master's in health professions	20%	**21%**[2025]	+1.6 pp ▲	15%	+1.7 pp ▲	#3	[4]
Share of master's in business	24%	**20%**[2025]	−4.0 pp ▼	21%	−3.2 pp ▼	#31	[4]
STEM share of research doctorates	31%	**26%**[2025]	−5.1 pp ▼	39%	−2.2 pp ▼	#44	[4]
Share of research doctorates in computer & information sciences	1.4%	**1.8%**[2025]	+0.4 pp ▲	4.2%	+1.4 pp ▲	#40	[4]
Share of research doctorates in engineering & eng. technology	11%	**9.6%**[2025]	−0.9 pp ▼	14%	−1.0 pp ▼	#39	[4]
Share of research doctorates in mathematics & statistics	1.4%	**1.4%**[2025]	0.0 pp	2.4%	−0.2 pp ▼	#33	[4]
Share of research doctorates in biological & biomedical sciences	12%	**9.0%**[2025]	−3.4 pp ▼	10%	−1.1 pp ▼	#35	[4]
Share of research doctorates in physical sciences	5.1%	**3.9%**[2025]	−1.1 pp ▼	7.1%	−1.1 pp ▼	#47	[4]
Share of research doctorates in health professions	19%	**19%**[2025]	−0.1 pp ▼	12%	+3.5 pp ▲	#12	[4]
Share of research doctorates in business	3.2%	**9.7%**[2025]	+6.5 pp ▲	5.6%	+1.3 pp ▲	#8	[4]
Bachelor's degrees per 100 undergraduates	12.2	**13.0**[2025]	+0.8 ▲	12.3	+1.4 ▲	#21	[4]
INTERNATIONAL STUDENTS							
First-time students from outside the U.S.	1.3%[2016]	**1.6%**[2024]	+0.3 pp ▲	3.1%	+0.1 pp ▲	#41	[4]
STEM master's degrees earned by international students	236	**1.14K**[2025]	4.83× ▲	117K	2.18× ▲	#23	[4]
Share of all U.S. international STEM master's degrees	0.4%	**1.0%**[2025]	+0.5 pp ▲	–	–	#23	[4]

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TENNESSEE – BY THE NUMBERS (CONTINUED)

Measure	2015	Latest	Change since 2015	U.S., latest	U.S. change since 2015	Rank	Source
INTERNATIONAL STUDENTS (CONTINUED)							
International share of undergraduate enrollment	2.2%	**2.0%**[2024]	−0.3 pp ▼	3.0%	−0.3 pp ▼	#37	[4]
International share of graduate enrollment	7.9%	**11%**[2024]	+2.7 pp ▲	17%	+2.8 pp ▲	#31	[4]
International share of all bachelor's	2.0%	**2.6%**[2025]	+0.6 pp ▲	4.1%	+0.1 pp ▲	#36	[4]
International share of STEM bachelor's	4.3%	**3.9%**[2025]	−0.4 pp ▼	6.6%	+0.8 pp ▲	#38	[4]
International share of all master's	6.6%	**14%**[2025]	+7.2 pp ▲	22%	+6.2 pp ▲	#28	[4]
International share of STEM master's	23%	**50%**[2025]	+27.3 pp ▲	52%	+9.1 pp ▲	#18	[4]
International share of computer & information sciences master's	33%	**76%**[2025]	+42.3 pp ▲	65%	+10.1 pp ▲	#14	[4]
International share of engineering & eng. technology master's	24%	**31%**[2025]	+6.6 pp ▲	50%	+0.9 pp ▲	#36	[4]
International share of mathematics & statistics master's	29%	**26%**[2025]	−2.6 pp ▼	55%	+6.1 pp ▲	#33	[4]
International share of biological & biomedical sciences master's	18%	**17%**[2025]	−0.7 pp ▼	23%	+6.2 pp ▲	#28	[4]
International share of physical sciences master's	23%	**47%**[2025]	+23.6 pp ▲	33%	+3.6 pp ▲	#5	[4]
International share of all research doctorates	16%	**15%**[2025]	−1.0 pp ▼	25%	−1.0 pp ▼	#44	[4]
International share of STEM research doctorates	36%	**35%**[2025]	−0.5 pp ▼	43%	−0.5 pp ▼	#40	[4]
International share of computer & information sciences research doctorates	61%[2024]	**59%**[2025]	−1.6 pp ▼	56%	−1.7 pp ▼	#13	[4]
International share of engineering & eng. technology research doctorates	49%	**47%**[2025]	−2.1 pp ▼	55%	−1.0 pp ▼	#34	[4]
International share of mathematics & statistics research doctorates	22%[2020]	**47%**[2025]	+24.4 pp ▲	53%	−1.9 pp ▼	#21	[4]
International share of biological & biomedical sciences research doctorates	22%	**19%**[2025]	−3.5 pp ▼	23%	−4.3 pp ▼	#31	[4]
International share of physical sciences research doctorates	34%	**33%**[2025]	−1.3 pp ▼	38%	−1.1 pp ▼	#32	[4]
Active F-1/M-1 students, all levels	10.6K	**13.7K**[2026]	+29% ▲	1.19M	−0.1% ▼	#23	[20]
Share of U.S. active F-1/M-1 students	0.9%	**1.1%**[2026]	+0.3 pp ▲	–	–	#23	[20]
Share of F-1/M-1 students from India	7.8%	**28%**[2026]	+20.4 pp ▲	27%	+11.4 pp ▲	#17	[20]
Share of F-1/M-1 students from China	21%	**10%**[2026]	−10.5 pp ▼	18%	−11.7 pp ▼	#27	[20]
Share from the two largest countries of origin	43%	**38%**[2026]	−4.9 pp ▼	45%	−0.3 pp ▼	#28	[20]

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TENNESSEE – BY THE NUMBERS (CONTINUED)

Measure	2015	Latest	Change since 2015	U.S., latest	U.S. change since 2015	Rank	Source
INTERNATIONAL STUDENTS (CONTINUED)							
Countries of citizenship represented	158	**169**[2026]	+7.0% ▲	219	−2.7% ▼	#22	[20]
Active STEM F-1/M-1 students	4.34K	**8.64K**[2026]	+99% ▲	749K	+61% ▲	#22	[20]
Active STEM master's students	907	**4.31K**[2026]	4.75× ▲	393K	+90% ▲	#20	[20]
Active STEM doctoral students	1.35K	**2.39K**[2026]	+77% ▲	158K	+61% ▲	#19	[20]
Share of STEM master's students from India	37%	**68%**[2026]	+30.6 pp ▲	58%	−1.8 pp ▼	#11	[20]
U.S. students studying abroad for credit, from the state's institutions	7.33K[2017]	**6.68K**[2024]	−8.9% ▼	–	–	#16	[1]
Economic contribution of international students, nominal dollars	$348M[2018]	**$385M**[2024]	+10% ▲	$42.9B	+4.6% ▲	#24	[2]
Jobs supported by international students' spending	4.36K[2018]	**3.34K**[2024]	−23% ▼	356K	−22% ▼	#24	[2]
Share of U.S. student and exchange-visitor admissions, by destination	0.7%	**0.7%**[2024]	+0.1 pp ▲	–	–	#24	[16]
Share of U.S. F-1 student admissions, by destination	0.6%	**0.6%**[2024]	0.0 pp	–	–	#24	[16]
Share of U.S. J-1 exchange-visitor admissions, by destination	0.8%	**1.2%**[2024]	+0.4 pp ▲	–	–	#23	[16]
J-1 exchange visitors starting a program in the state	3.35K	**4.35K**[2025]	+30% ▲	275K	−14% ▼	#22	[18]
GRADUATE EDUCATION AND RESEARCH							
Graduate students in science & engineering	7.23K	**7.12K**[2016]	−1.5% ▼	620K	+0.4% ▲	#25	[9]
S&E graduate students on temporary visas	1.99K	**1.93K**[2016]	−3.3% ▼	241K	+2.3% ▲	#30	[9]
Temporary-visa share of S&E graduate students	28%	**27%**[2016]	−0.5 pp ▼	39%	+0.7 pp ▲	#39	[9]
Temporary-visa share of engineering graduate students	41%	**40%**[2016]	−1.0 pp ▼	57%	0.0 pp	#41	[9]
S&E postdoctoral appointees	616	**602**[2016]	−2.3% ▼	45.7K	+1.0% ▲	#23	[9]
Temporary-visa share of S&E postdocs	52%	**52%**[2016]	+0.2 pp ▲	56%	−0.9 pp ▼	#30	[9]
University R&D spending, nominal dollars	$1.08B	**$2.12B**[2024]	+97% ▲	$118B	+71% ▲	#18	[6]
Share of U.S. university R&D	1.6%	**1.8%**[2024]	+0.2 pp ▲	–	–	#18	[6]
Federally funded share of university R&D	58%	**55%**[2024]	−3.0 pp ▼	55%	−0.2 pp ▼	#19	[6]
Business-funded share of university R&D	4.9%	**4.8%**[2024]	−0.1 pp ▼	5.4%	−0.4 pp ▼	#20	[6]
State- and locally funded share of university R&D	2.9%	**2.3%**[2024]	−0.6 pp ▼	5.2%	−0.4 pp ▼	#41	[6]
University R&D in mathematics and computer science, nominal dollars	$30.7M	**$58.8M**[2024]	+92% ▲	$5.12B	+97% ▲	#20	[6]

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TENNESSEE – BY THE NUMBERS (CONTINUED)

Measure	2015	Latest	Change since 2015	U.S., latest	U.S. change since 2015	Rank	Source
GRADUATE EDUCATION AND RESEARCH (CONTINUED)							
University R&D in engineering, nominal dollars	$156M	**$263M[2024]**	+69% ▲	$19.3B	+74% ▲	#21	[6]
University R&D personnel, headcount	16.3K	**20.7K[2024]**	+27% ▲	1.09M	+20% ▲	#19	[6]
Federal R&D obligations to the state, nominal dollars	$2.31B	**$3.89B[2024]**	+68% ▲	$193B	+53% ▲	#15	[8]
Federal R&D obligations to universities in the state, nominal dollars	$493M	**$1.01B[2024]**	2.04× ▲	$44.4B	+64% ▲	#15	[8]
Defense R&D obligations to the state, nominal dollars	$303M	**$904M[2024]**	2.98× ▲	$97.2B	+60% ▲	#22	[8]
Health (HHS/NIH) R&D obligations to the state, nominal dollars	$444M	**$855M[2024]**	+93% ▲	$48.5B	+62% ▲	#15	[8]
NSF, NIH, NASA and DOE Science grants performed in the state, nominal dollars	$498M	**$843M[2025]**	+69% ▲	$45B	+47% ▲	#17	[19]
Federal R&D contracts performed in the state, nominal dollars	$388M	**$84.2M[2026]**	−303.3 ▼	$59.3B	+22,105.9 ▲	#31	[19]
COLLEGE COSTS AND OUTCOMES							
Median earnings 10 years after entering college	$43K[2020]	**$44K[2022]**	+2.4% ▲	$47.5K	+11% ▲	#38	[15]
Median earnings 1 year after completing	–	**$44.6K[2025]**	–	$47.5K	–	#45	[15]
Median debt of completers, nominal dollars	$20.3K	**$18.8K[2024]**	−7.4% ▼	$17.6K	−4.6% ▼	#32	[15]
STEM bachelor's graduates: median earnings 1 year out	–	**$66.2K[2025]**	–	$68.2K	–	#28	[15]
Non-STEM bachelor's graduates: median earnings 1 year out	–	**$49.2K[2025]**	–	$51.9K	–	#33	[15]
Bachelor's graduates: median earnings 5 years out	–	**$60K[2025]**	–	$68.1K	–	#46	[15]
STEM master's graduates: median earnings 1 year out	–	**$86.6K[2025]**	–	$91.6K	–	#25	[15]
Six-year bachelor's graduation rate, 4-year institutions	50%	**58%[2024]**	+8.2 pp ▲	65%	+5.3 pp ▲	#36	[4]
Completion within 150% of normal time, 2-year institutions	28%	**34%[2024]**	+5.9 pp ▲	41%	+12.1 pp ▲	#39	[4]
In-state tuition & fees, public 4-year	$11.9K	**$11K[2023]**	−7.3% ▼	$9.71K	−14% ▼	#19	[4]
State & local appropriations per FTE, public institutions	$7.37K	**$12.1K[2024]**	+64% ▲	$11.4K	+22% ▲	#13	[4]
Net tuition share of tuition plus state and local appropriations, public institutions	50%	**37%[2024]**	−13.0 pp ▼	43%	−5.9 pp ▼	#39	[4]
Average full-time faculty salary (9/10-month)	$98.1K[2016]	**$92.8K[2024]**	−5.5% ▼	$106K	−4.6% ▼	#33	[4]
WHERE STUDENTS AND GRADUATES GO							

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TENNESSEE – BY THE NUMBERS (CONTINUED)

Measure	2015	Latest	Change since 2015	U.S., latest	U.S. change since 2015	Rank	Source
WHERE STUDENTS AND GRADUATES GO (CONTINUED)							
International graduates on OPT working in the state where they studied	38%	**42%**[2016]	+3.7 pp ▲	44%	−1.8 pp ▼	#19	[21]
OPT retention, bachelor's graduates	57%	**57%**[2016]	−0.2 pp ▼	58%	+0.3 pp ▲	#14	[21]
OPT retention, master's graduates	36%	**39%**[2016]	+3.1 pp ▲	39%	−2.5 pp ▼	#21	[21]
OPT retention, STEM graduates	35%	**41%**[2016]	+6.2 pp ▲	37%	−1.9 pp ▼	#14	[21]
OPT workers employed in the state per OPT graduate of its schools	1.08	**1.18**[2016]	+0.1 ▲	1.00	0.0	#8	[21]
STEM OPT extensions approved, by state of the school	167	**201**[2016]	+20% ▲	41.2K	+51% ▲	#33	[21]
Bachelor's graduates working in the state 1 year after graduating (PSEO)	79%[2016]	**78%**[2019]	−0.9 pp ▼	72%	−0.1 pp ▼	#5	[11]
Bachelor's graduates working in the state 5 years after graduating (PSEO)	–	**73%**[2016]	–	65%	–	#4	[11]
Bachelor's graduates working in the state 10 years after graduating (PSEO)	–	**68%**[2010]	–	64%	–	#4	[11]
STEM bachelor's graduates working in the state 1 year out (PSEO)	71%[2016]	**73%**[2019]	+1.4 pp ▲	67%	+1.5 pp ▲	#5	[11]
Master's graduates working in the state 1 year out (PSEO)	–	**71%**[2016]	–	66%	–	#9	[11]
Doctoral graduates working in the state 1 year out (PSEO)	–	**52%**[2016]	–	49%	–	#9	[11]
Bachelor's graduates' median earnings 1 year out (PSEO)	$41.9K[2016]	**$43.6K**[2019]	+4.1% ▲	$48.1K	+2.3% ▲	#29	[11]
Bachelor's graduates' median earnings 5 years out (PSEO)	–	**$58.8K**[2016]	–	$67.3K	–	#35	[11]
STEM bachelor's graduates' median earnings 1 year out (PSEO)	$55.2K[2016]	**$54.2K**[2019]	−1.7% ▼	$59.3K	+0.1% ▲	#27	[11]
Net domestic migration of bachelor's-plus adults, per 1,000 residents	+6.3	**+0.5**[2025]	−5.8 ▼	–	–	#28	[12]
Net domestic migration of graduate-degree holders	+4.71K	**+1.51K**[2025]	−3,202.0 ▼	–	–	#14	[12]
Bachelor's-plus adults who moved in from another state	3.8%	**3.2%**[2025]	−0.6 pp ▼	–	–	#19	[12]
Bachelor's-plus adults who moved out to another state	3.2%	**3.1%**[2025]	−0.1 pp ▼	–	–	#16	[12]
Bachelor's-plus adults who arrived from abroad in the past year	6.13K	**7.87K**[2025]	+28% ▲	–	–	#19	[12]
First-time students who are in-state residents	81%[2016]	**76%**[2024]	−4.9 pp ▼	–	–	#19	[4]
Net student migration (per 100 resident first-time students)	+2[2016]	**+1**[2024]	−1.3 ▼	–	–	#34	[4]

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TENNESSEE – BY THE NUMBERS (CONTINUED)

Measure	2015	Latest	Change since 2015	U.S., latest	U.S. change since 2015	Rank	Source
WHERE STUDENTS AND GRADUATES GO (CONTINUED)							
Recent high school graduates who go to college out of state	15%[2016]	**19%[2022]**	+3.6 pp ▲	22%	+2.5 pp ▲	#31	[3]
WORK VISAS AND GREEN CARDS							
Certified H-1B positions, by worksite	16.5K	**8.81K[2025]**	−47% ▼	914K	−24% ▼	#19	[17]
Share of U.S. certified H-1B positions	1.4%	**1.0%[2025]**	−0.4 pp ▼	–	–	#19	[17]
STEM share of certified H-1B positions	93%	**79%[2025]**	−13.6 pp ▼	76%	−7.8 pp ▼	#12	[17]
Median offered H-1B wage, nominal dollars, nominal dollars	$68K	**$99.7K[2025]**	+47% ▲	$119K	+66% ▲	#30	[17]
H-1B positions at H-1B-dependent employers	73%	**20%[2025]**	−52.9 pp ▼	22%	−25.7 pp ▼	#22	[17]
Green-card labor certifications	359	**1.16K[2025]**	3.23× ▲	138K	+75% ▲	#24	[17]
Share of PERM certifications for citizens of India	53%	**36%[2024]**	−17.4 pp ▼	47%	−10.6 pp ▼	#26	[17]
PERM certifications for workers on F-1 student visas	3.3%	**9.6%[2024]**	+6.3 pp ▲	8.7%	+4.9 pp ▲	#26	[17]
PERM workers with a master's or doctorate	56%	**37%[2024]**	−19.4 pp ▼	47%	−4.9 pp ▼	#28	[17]
STEM share of PERM certifications	64%	**46%[2025]**	−18.5 pp ▼	49%	−25.8 pp ▼	#20	[17]
Median offered PERM wage, nominal dollars, nominal dollars	$80.1K	**$83.6K[2025]**	+4.4% ▲	$100K	+9.9% ▲	#27	[17]
New lawful permanent residents (green cards), by state of residence	8.83K	**13.4K[2024]**	+51% ▲	1.36M	+30% ▲	#20	[16]
Share of U.S. new green-card holders	0.8%	**1.0%[2024]**	+0.1 pp ▲	–	–	#20	[16]
People naturalized as U.S. citizens, by state of residence	5.38K	**7.81K[2024]**	+45% ▲	819K	+12% ▲	#22	[16]
Share of U.S. naturalizations	0.7%	**1.0%[2024]**	+0.2 pp ▲	–	–	#22	[16]
Share of U.S. temporary-worker admissions, by destination	0.7%	**0.8%[2024]**	+0.1 pp ▲	–	–	#17	[16]
Share of U.S. H-1B worker admissions, by destination	0.6%	**0.6%[2024]**	0.0 pp	–	–	#22	[16]
Share of U.S. L-1 intracompany-transferee admissions, by destination	0.8%	**1.1%[2024]**	+0.3 pp ▲	–	–	#15	[16]
Share of U.S. O-1 extraordinary-ability worker admissions, by destination	0.6%	**1.1%[2024]**	+0.5 pp ▲	–	–	#13	[16]
New H-1B approvals (initial), by employer state	794	**1.46K[2026]**	+84% ▲	127K	+14% ▲	#17	[13]
Continuing H-1B approvals, by employer state	1.53K	**3.65K[2026]**	2.39× ▲	268K	+52% ▲	#16	[13]
Share of U.S. new H-1B approvals	0.7%	**1.1%[2026]**	+0.4 pp ▲	–	–	#17	[13]

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TENNESSEE – BY THE NUMBERS (CONTINUED)

Measure	2015	Latest	Change since 2015	U.S., latest	U.S. change since 2015	Rank	Source
WORK VISAS AND GREEN CARDS (CONTINUED)							
Denial rate, new H-1B petitions	2.3%	**2.3%**[2026]	−0.1 pp ▼	3.4%	−3.0 pp ▼	#45	[13]
New H-1B approvals at colleges and schools (NAICS 61)	20%	**12%**[2026]	−8.2 pp ▼	8.6%	−1.7 pp ▼	#34	[13]
New H-1B approvals in professional, scientific & technical services	22%	**18%**[2026]	−4.3 pp ▼	44%	−12.5 pp ▼	#39	[13]
Five largest employers' share of new H-1B approvals	52%	**33%**[2026]	−19.4 pp ▼	9.1%	−6.7 pp ▼	#26	[13]
STEM WORKFORCE AND INNOVATION							
Workers in STEM occupations	142K	**226K**[2024]	+59% ▲	13.7M	+51% ▲	#20	[12]
STEM workers as a share of all workers	4.7%	**6.3%**[2024]	+1.6 pp ▲	8.1%	+2.1 pp ▲	#35	[12]
Foreign-born share of STEM workers	11%	**12%**[2024]	+1.5 pp ▲	24%	+1.6 pp ▲	#33	[12]
Foreign-born share of STEM workers with a graduate degree	21%	**26%**[2024]	+4.6 pp ▲	41%	+2.2 pp ▲	#27	[12]
Foreign-born share of STEM workers with a doctorate	27%[2021]	**37%**[2024]	+9.2 pp ▲	47%	+0.8 pp ▲	#17	[12]
Noncitizen share of STEM workers	5.1%	**6.7%**[2024]	+1.6 pp ▲	11%	+0.7 pp ▲	#25	[12]
STEM workers born abroad who arrived in the last 10 years	3.4%	**4.9%**[2024]	+1.5 pp ▲	7.5%	+0.3 pp ▲	#21	[12]
Share of foreign-born STEM workers born in India	28%	**28%**[2024]	+0.1 pp ▲	28%	+0.7 pp ▲	#18	[12]
Foreign-born share of residents	5.0%	**6.8%**[2025]	+1.7 pp ▲	15%	+1.3 pp ▲	#32	[12]
Foreign-born share of graduate-degree holders, 25+	7.5%	**11%**[2025]	+3.3 pp ▲	21%	+2.8 pp ▲	#32	[12]
STEM jobs, employer survey	118K	**167K**[2025]	+41% ▲	10.4M	+26% ▲	#20	[10]
STEM jobs concentration vs the U.S., location quotient	0.70	**0.76**[2025]	+0.1 ▲	1.00	0.0	#40	[10]
Mean annual STEM wage, nominal, nominal dollars	$72.9K	**$101K**[2025]	+39% ▲	$120K	+38% ▲	#33	[10]
Median software developer wage, nominal, nominal dollars	$90.9K[2019]	**$122K**[2025]	+35% ▲	$136K	+26% ▲	#35	[10]
Software developer jobs	8.9K	**19K**[2025]	2.14× ▲	1.69M	+48% ▲	#23	[10]
Mean annual wage, all occupations, nominal, nominal dollars	$41.3K	**$60.8K**[2025]	+47% ▲	$69.8K	+44% ▲	#40	[10]
Patents granted to assignees in the state	732	**984**[2025]	+35% ▲	135K	−0.6% ▼	#28	[22]
Share of U.S.-assignee patents	0.5%	**0.7%**[2025]	+0.2 pp ▲	–	–	#28	[22]
Share of the state's patents in digital technologies	8.2%	**11%**[2025]	+3.2 pp ▲	43%	+1.6 pp ▲	#39	[22]
Share of the state's patents in life sciences	37%	**33%**[2025]	−4.2 pp ▼	17%	+0.4 pp ▲	#8	[22]

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TENNESSEE – BY THE NUMBERS (CONTINUED)

Measure	2015	Latest	Change since 2015	U.S., latest	U.S. change since 2015	Rank	Source
STEM WORKFORCE AND INNOVATION (CONTINUED)							
Share of the state's patents in semiconductors	0.9%	**0.3%**[2025]	−0.7 pp ▼	2.9%	−1.7 pp ▼	#39	[22]
Women's share of inventors on the state's patents	11%	**11%**[2025]	0.0 pp	14%	+3.4 pp ▲	#28	[22]

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